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- Narendra Modi, Prime Minister

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CBC 03111/13/0002/2627

THREATENS TO HAMPER NEGOTIATIONS

Israel strikes Beirut suburbs in lead-up to US-Iran deal

JERUSALEM: The Israeli military said it launched strikes on Hezbollah targets in Beirut on Sunday despite ongoing efforts to negotiate an end to the US-Iran war. Smoke could be seen rising over the Lebanese capital.

The strikes threatened to hamper negotiations over a deal, which in its current form is a deep disappointment to Israel's government. The last time Israel struck the Beirut suburbs a week ago, it set off the most serious escalation of fighting between Iran and Israel since the tenuous ceasefire took hold April 7.

The office of Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said the strikes were in response to Hezbollah attacks on the north of the country. Israel's military said earlier in the day that Hezbollah had launched three projectiles into northern Israel, releasing footage where an audible boom was followed by a column of smoke rising above the tree line.

An Associated Press photographer at the scene in Beirut said the building struck was a five-story apartment building with shops on the bottom floor. The two lower floors were the most heavily damaged by the strikes. There was no word on casualties. Residents of the southern suburbs, many of whom had returned to their homes after a period of relative calm in recent weeks, could be seen fleeing the area.

Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel on March 2, two days after the US and Israel



There was no immediate comment from Hezbollah

attacked Iran, sparking war in the Middle East. Israeli troops have pushed their invasion of Lebanon deeper than at any

point in over a quarter century. Iran wants a ceasefire deal to include the fighting in Lebanon and seeks the release of bil-



Strike comes as mediators push Iran and the US closer to a deal

Highlights

- » The last time Israel struck the Beirut suburbs a week ago
- » Israeli PM office says the strikes were in response to Hezbollah attacks
- » Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel on March 2, two days after the US and Israel attacked Iran

lions of dollars in frozen funds. But as talks continued, Israel has been sidelined in negotiations led by Pakistan and others.

"Israel will not tolerate firing into its territory," a statement from Netanyahu and Defence Minister Israel Katz said Sunday. Trump has pressed Netanyahu to stop hitting Lebanon hard while a deal is near, but the prime minister has defied him.

Iran's parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf warned on X that Israel's strikes on Beirut's suburbs

show that "America either lacks the will to fulfil its commitments or the ability to do so." He warned that the strikes could imperil the final stage of negotiations.

There was no immediate comment from Hezbollah. Qatari mediators travelled to Tehran on Sunday to finalise the agreement, according to two regional officials.

The officials, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media, expressed cautious optimism that the US and Iran were finally approaching an agreement that could halt hostilities that have killed thousands of people and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, whose closure has thrown world markets into disarray. US President Donald Trump and Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said Saturday that the deal would be signed on Sunday, while Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said it could happen in the coming days.

AGENCIES

Palestinian death toll in Gaza tops 73,000: Officials

DEIR AL-BALAH: Gaza's Health Ministry says the Palestinian death toll from the Israel-Hamas war has surpassed 73,000.

The updated toll on Sunday came as Israel has continued to strike despite a fragile ceasefire deal reached in October.

Confirmation came from Zaher al-Waheidi, head of the ministry's records department, and Hamza Salem from the ministry's public relations department. The total number of deaths since the beginning of the war is now 73,001.

On Sunday, the ministry said, there were five deaths: two in the southern city of Khan Younis and one in central Gaza, in addition to two who died of earlier wounds.

Over 1,73,200 people have been wounded since the start of the war, which was ignited by the Hamas-led October 7, 2023 attack into Israel. That attack killed some 1,200 people and took 251 others hostage.

An Israeli strike on Saturday evening killed two Palestinians in Khan Younis. The



Palestinians inspect buildings that were destroyed in an Israeli airstrike, at al-Maghazi refugee camp

AP/PTI

casualties were taken to Nasser hospital, according to the Palestinian Red Crescent Society.

The Israeli military did not immediately respond to a request for comment.

The health ministry, part of the Hamas-led government, is staffed by medical professionals and maintains detailed records viewed as generally reliable by United Nations agencies and independent experts. It does not say how

many of those killed were civilians or militants.

It says women and children make up around half of all fatalities. Israel says it tries to avoid harming civilians and blames their deaths on Hamas because the militants operate in densely populated areas. It says it is carrying out strikes against militants who pose a threat, and in response to ceasefire violations, including occasional attacks.

AGENCIES

Health workers struggle to contain Ebola in Congo camps as distrust grows

NIZI: After the Kpangba displacement camp became the first in this part of war-torn Congo to record deaths from Ebola two weeks ago, health workers rushed to trace those who had come into contact with the deceased to break chains of transmission.

But the workers - from the provincial health ministry, the World Health Organization and other aid agencies - were forced away by angry locals who denied that the two women had died from Ebola, said Jean-Claude Lonzama, the chief doctor for the local health zone of Nizi, a heavily populated mining area.

Up to this day, we are not able to follow up on the contacts of these cases," Lonzama told Reuters on Saturday.

The standoff has left health authorities flying blind as they try to stave off a surge of Ebola cases in this camp of

around 30,000 people, most of whom have fled inter-ethnic violence in surrounding areas. "We have 22 displaced persons sites in the Nizi health zone ... with around 81,124 residents," Lonzama said.

"This is also our great worry because no preventive measures have been put in place in these sites aside from a few educational messages."

Since the outbreak was declared a month ago, several treatment sites have been attacked by locals angry about not being able to bury their loved ones because of precautions taken to keep the virus from spreading or convinced Ebola is a hoax.

Aid workers fear Ebola could spread quickly in this and other displacement camps accelerating the spread of what is already one of the world's largest-ever outbreaks.

AGENCIES

UK intercept Russian shadow fleet vessel in English Channel

LONDON: British armed forces intercepted a sanctioned Russian shadow fleet oil tanker in the English Channel on Sunday morning in the first UK-led operation of its kind.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer confirmed that the vessel SMYRTOS was boarded by Royal Marine Commandos and specially trained law enforcement officers from the National Crime Agency (NCA).

The military operation, which lasted six hours, was supported with aircraft from the Maritime Air Group, a Royal Air Force (RAF) P-8 aircraft, as well as HMS Sutherland and HMS Ledbury.

"This operation delivers yet another blow to Russia and reminds those fuelling (Russian President Vladimir) Putin's war in Ukraine that they cannot hide," said Starmer.

AGENCIES

Trump ready to help end Ukraine conflict: Kremlin



Russian President Vladimir Putin

MOSCOW: U.S. President Donald Trump told Russian President Vladimir Putin on Sunday that ending the conflict in Ukraine was vital and he was ready to help, Russian news agencies quoted Kremlin foreign policy adviser Yuri Ushakov as saying.

"As regards the Ukrainian conflict, Donald Trump again emphasised that a cessation of hostilities was vital," Ushakov was quoted as telling journalists.

"He said he was ready to act with European partners

and Kyiv, including in talks at the G7 summit," he added, referring to the summit of G7 industrialised countries this week in France.

Ushakov told the journalists that U.S. envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner, who have led U.S.-brokered negotiations aimed at ending the Ukraine war, would soon be undertaking another visit to Russia. Diplomatic efforts on ending the Ukraine war have stalled as Washington remains focused on the conflict in Iran.

AGENCIES

Ukrainian drone strikes kill 1, spark fire at oil facility in Russia

MOSCOW: A Ukrainian drone attack killed one person in Russia's southwestern Oryol region, local officials said Sunday, while a separate strike hit an oil facility as part of Kyiv's campaign of strikes on military and energy targets deep inside Russia. Oryol regional

Gov. Andrei Klychkov said Sunday that one person died and nine were wounded when a Ukrainian drone struck a residential building overnight in the regional capital, also called Oryol. Local authorities in Russia's Yaroslavl region, around 700 kilometres from the Ukrai-

nian border, said fuel storage facilities caught fire after being hit by a drone. Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said his country's forces had "struck an oil facility that was important for the reserve of the aggressor state" in the Yaroslavl region.

AGENCIES

Trump turns 80, hosts UFC fight night at White House

WASHINGTON: The White House on Sunday is witnessing a "fight night" in an octagon-shaped cage as the Ultimate Fighting Championship (UFC) fighters slug it out in the marquee event on the South Lawn on a day President Donald Trump turned 80.

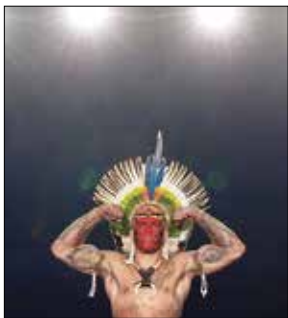
The fight night will feature seven bouts with UFC fighters in the Octagon - the cage set up for the event - with over 4,000 "special invitee" spectators cheering at the South Lawns arena and another estimated 75,000 audience gath-

ering on the Ellipse - a 52-acre park south of the White House - where giant screens will carry the proceedings live.

President Trump and his family members will cheer the fighters from the ringside along with Hollywood stars and special invitees.

Rows of bleachers have been built around the Octagon, which sat beneath a massive support structure known as "The Claw", for the president's special guests and members of the military.

Polish media reported



that Poland's President Karol Nawrocki, who is visiting the US, will attend the event as a spectator.

The cage fight has drawn sharp criticism from Democrats, who describe it as a garish spectacle at a time when the US is engaged in a war with Iran that has led to high cost of living for ordinary Americans.

"A UFC cage. A Tesla showroom. A gold-encrusted ballroom. Trump has been busy turning the White House front lawn into his billionaire playground. What has he done for American families," said Senator Elizabeth Warren, a Democrat from Massachusetts.

The supporters of the UFC event point out that the White House, often called the People's House, has hosted boxing and wrestling matches earlier.

"As the White House hosts a UFC event on June 14, we're reminded that Theodore Roosevelt brought his own fighting spirit to 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue.

Theodore Roosevelt often boxed and wrestled inside the White House, once suffering a permanent eye injury during a sparring match," Doug Burgum, US Interior Secretary,

said in a post on X.

The White House event is expected to cost around USD 60 million, a tab picked up entirely by the UFC.

The broader argument is that UFC is a sport enjoyed by millions, and the sheer spectacle of the event is fun and reflective of the American spirit.

The US Department of State has also signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the UFC to use the mixed martial arts cagefights as a tool of sports diplomacy.

AGENCIES

Romanian Prez nominates new candidate for PM

WARSAW: Romania's centrist President Nicusor Dan on Sunday designated Adrian Veste, a member of the liberal party, as prime minister, after independent candidate Eugen Tomac withdrew.

Veste, 52, is the county council president of the central Romanian county of Braso. Eugen Tomac had been seeking to lead a government of technocrats, but lacked support from the parties in parliament.

"Eugen Tomac withdrew his mandate this morning and as such I nominate Adrian Veste as prime minister," centrist President Nicusor Dan said on Sunday. "At the moment it is clear that a political (government) solution is the right one."

Parliamentary parties have previously said that a minority political government, without a permanent majority in parliament, would be better than a government of technocrats.

Dan is seeking to end a political crisis that has stalled policymaking, endangered access to EU funds and driven the leu currency to record lows.

AGENCIES

Thousands gather in Geneva to protest G7 as Trump, other leaders hold summit in nearby France

Demonstrators have been gathering for days in advance of Sunday's march in Geneva

GENEVA: Thousands of demonstrators converged Sunday to show their discontent against the G7 group of rich countries, with US President Donald Trump and counterparts set to hold a summit starting a day later in nearby France.

Environmentalists and feminists joined foes of imperialism, defenders of independent media, supporters of Palestinian rights and others in a lake-side park in Geneva for a march across town. A boat whose sail read "No G7" floated by, as sunbathers and swimmers basked under blue skies.

Swiss and French authorities have deployed thousands of police to provide security for the three-day summit starting Monday in the resort town of Evian-les-Bains, France. The leaders are set to discuss issues including the Middle East, Ukraine and global economic imbalances.

Authorities have blocked off roads, banned unauthorised gatherings and pledged financial support for businesses who could be hit by unrest. Scores



Representational Image

of businesses and shops have boarded up their storefronts with wooden panels as a precaution - leery of upheaval that left a trail of damage in Geneva during a similar summit in Evian in 2003. Only seven of the 35 roadway border crossings will remain open.

Demonstrators have been gathering for days in advance of Sunday's march in Geneva, the largest city in the area and designated gathering spot for

activists who oppose the G7.

A flotilla of around 20 boats appeared on Lake Geneva off the coast of Evian on Saturday, displaying anti-G7 and pro-Palestinian banners. Some 20 protesters were detained on Friday evening, according to Swiss media reports.

Earlier, between 100 and 150 people had gathered in Geneva for a protest bicycle ride, slowing down traffic and chanting anti-G7 and pro-Pal-

Swiss and French authorities have deployed thousands of police to provide security for the three-day summit starting Monday in the resort town of Evian-les-Bains, France

estinian slogans, public broadcaster RTS reported.

Local resident Robin Hedz lamented the "mess" and expressed bafflement about the "wood-wall everywhere," while acknowledging the memories of the trail of damaged property at the summit over 20 years ago. France will deploy more than 13,000 police and gendarmerie officers to ensure security in the summit area just across the border. Over 800 French border control officers will be active, up from about 60 normally.

French gendarmes buzzed around in motorboats off the coast of Evian on Saturday, and one officer hoisted up a bulky drone-interception device in a display of the security measures being rolled out for the summit.

Protests are nothing new around such elite gatherings. This time, activists want to demonstrate frustration with Trump's leadership on issues as diverse as tariffs, the war in Iran and the climate, or even highlight his past ties to convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

"We are very afraid of the policy and the politics of Mr. Trump and also of the other leaders of the G7, because they are fighting, making war all over the place," said Francoise Nyffeler, spokesperson for the NoG7 coalition, which has organised the demonstration and march on Sunday.

"The planet is in danger and we are very scared about it and we want to protest and say that the people of the world are against their policies," she added.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

NEPAL: 2 INDIAN NATIONALS ARRESTED FOR SUSPECTED DRUG TRAFFICKING

KATHMANDU: Two Indian nationals were among three people arrested in Nepal for allegedly possessing a huge quantity of narcotic drugs, police said. The Nepal police arrested the Indian nationals identified as Ahmad Ladin, 32, and Mohamad Saddam, 33, hailing from Sitamarhi district, Bihar, on Saturday. A Nepalese citizen, Jitendra Paswan, was also arrested by the police. The arrests were made after police opened fire on the suspects when they did not stop at a security check, officials said. Around 30,000 capsules of Tramadol, a kind of drug used as a painkiller and for intoxication, were recovered from the suspects, said officials.

NEPAL BEGINS EXPORTING 40 MW ELECTRICITY TO BANGLADESH FROM JUNE 15

KATHMANDU: Nepal will export 40 MW electricity to Bangladesh from Sunday midnight according to a tripartite agreement involving the two countries and India signed in 2024, the Nepal Electricity Authority said. Nepal had also sought permission from the Indian authorities for exporting additional 20 MW of hydro-electricity from this season, but it did not receive a green signal, said Tharka Bahadur Thapa, director of trade department of the Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA). Nepal has been exporting its surplus electricity to India and Bangladesh during monsoon season. In November last year, Bangladesh had agreed to import additional 20 MW electricity.

172 FARMERS TO TAKE SPECIAL LUCKNOW FLIGHT

Noida Int’l Airport gears up for operational debut today

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: In a unique gesture to recognise the contribution of farmers who gave up their land for the Noida International Airport project, the Uttar Pradesh government will fly 172 of them to Lucknow on June 15 as part of the airport's inaugural operations. The farmers will also have an opportunity to interact with Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath during the visit.

According to the flight schedule, the first aircraft will arrive at Noida International Airport from Lucknow at 8.05 am and depart for Bengaluru at 8.35 am. Another flight is scheduled to leave for Lucknow at 9 am. The 180-seat Lucknow-bound flight has been reserved for farmers whose land contributed to the development of the airport.



The arrangement was reportedly made following a recommendation by Jewar MLA Dharendra Singh.

The inaugural flight from Lucknow to Jewar is expected to carry Union and state ministers, elected representatives, senior aviation officials and industry leaders.

The Corridor Region Committee (CRC) has also reserved 70 seats for entrepreneurs, who will be introduced to investment opportunities and industrial prospects in the region. Officials from the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) are also likely to be on board.

Authorities said the initiative is intended to honour the farmers whose cooperation made possible the development of the mega infrastructure project spread across thousands of acres in Jewar.

Meanwhile, security arrangements have been significantly strengthened ahead

CLOSER LOOK

» The inaugural flight from Lucknow to Jewar is expected to carry Union and state ministers, elected representatives, senior aviation officials and industry leaders

» The Corridor Region Committee has also reserved 70 seats for entrepreneurs, who will be introduced to investment opportunities and industrial prospects in region

of the airport's launch. Gautam Buddh Nagar Police Commissioner Laxmi Singh reviewed security, traffic management and emergency response preparedness, directing officials to ensure seamless operations at the airport and surrounding areas once commercial services commence.

Tillu Tajpuria gang associates held with pistols & cartridges

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two alleged members of the Tillu Tajpuria gang were arrested with illegal firearms and ammunition in Outer Delhi, police said on Sunday.

Vishal Pandit and Deepanshu, aged 22 and 26, were apprehended by the Crime Branch after an intelligence input about their movement in the Holambi Khurd area, they said.

According to the police, the two were carrying an illegal semi-automatic pistol each and six live cartridges.

A car allegedly used by them for criminal activities was also seized.

During interrogation, Pandit and Deepanshu revealed that they were active associates of the Tajpuria gang and were in touch with other gang members through social media, the police said.

Investigators suspect their links to a recent firing incident in Outer Delhi.

At the time of their arrest,



“After Tajpuria's death, his gang's activities were being coordinated by Himmat

they were allegedly collecting information about members of the rival Gogi gang.

Hostilities between the two gangs ratcheted up in the wake of the killing of Tajpuria in 2023 inside Tihar jail.

According to the police, preliminary investigation indicated that after Tajpuria's death, his gang's activities were being coordinated by Himmat alias Cheeku, who has been absconding since he jumped parole in a case reg-

istered under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA).

Pandit and Deepanshu also disclosed that they had recently been supplied firearms and ammunition by gang handlers and were awaiting instructions regarding potential targets, the police said.

The two were previously involved in multiple criminal cases, including those related to an attempt to murder, extortion and violations of the Arms Act.

Fire at South Delhi eatery brought under control after cylinder blasts

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out at a restaurant near the Kalkaji-Govind Puri flyover in South Delhi's Nehru Place area early on Sunday morning, prompting a major firefighting operation during which an elderly woman was rescued from the building.

According to police, the incident was reported at around 4.45 am at Punjabi Tadka, located in H-Block near Anjali Jewellers and Desh Bandhu Gupta College.

The blaze engulfed a building comprising a basement, ground floor and three upper floors, along with a temporary structure erected on the terrace of the third floor.

During firefighting operations, three commercial LPG cylinders exploded, intensifying the blaze and creating



Fire officials said the exact cause of the blaze is yet to be ascertained. No fatalities had been reported at the time

additional challenges for rescue teams.

Despite the hazardous conditions, personnel from the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) res-

cued an elderly woman, identified as Sita Devi, aged between 70 and 75 years, from the second floor of the building. She was brought to safety and no serious injuries were immediately reported.

Assistant Divisional Officer (ADO) Yashwant said that the fire had been brought under control by around 5.45 am and a "stop" message had been issued. Cooling operations, however, continued at the site to eliminate any possibility of the fire reigniting.

Fire officials said the exact cause of the blaze is yet to be ascertained. No fatalities had been reported at the time of filing this report.

Authorities are expected to conduct a detailed inspection of the premises to determine the origin of the fire and assess the extent of structural damage caused by the incident.

Police bust investment fraud racket, nab India-based handler of Ukraine network

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Cyber Cell of Delhi Police has busted an online investment fraud racket and arrested a 52-year-old man allegedly acting as the India-based handler of a cyber-crime network operating from Ukraine.

The case came to light following a complaint registered at the Cyber Police Station, North-East district. The accused, identified as Santosh Kumar Gupta (52), a resident of Kharar in Chandigarh, was arrested in connection with an e-FIR registered under Section 318(4) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

According to police, the complainant, Arvind Dhama, was duped by fraudsters who lured him into investing money with promises of high returns. Believing the scheme to be gen-



uine, he transferred Rs 18.39 lakh through four separate transactions. After receiving the money, the fraudsters allegedly stopped all communication, leaving him unable to recover his funds.

During the investigation, police traced Rs 5 lakh of the cheated amount to a bank account belonging to a labourer. The money was allegedly withdrawn on the same day it was deposited, raising suspicions about the use of

mule accounts to channel proceeds of cyber fraud.

A dedicated team comprising SI Mohit Kumar, ASI Manoj Kumar, Head Constable Sandeep and Constable Kapil Sharma, under the supervision of Inspector Rahul Kumar, SHO of the Cyber Police Station, conducted extensive technical and financial analysis to identify those involved. The investigation eventually led to the arrest of Gupta.

During interrogation,

Further investigation is underway to identify other members of network

Gupta allegedly confessed to arranging bank accounts that were used to receive, transfer and withdraw money generated through cyber fraud. He further disclosed that he was in contact with a foreign-based associate who paid him commissions for facilitating accounts used in online scams.

Police recovered an Oppo mobile phone and two SIM cards belonging to Airtel and Jio networks from the accused.

Further investigation is underway to identify other members of the international cyber fraud network and ascertain the full extent of the racket.

Demolition drive near PM's residence removes 3 slum clusters

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A demolition drive was carried out on Sunday in slum clusters near the Race Course in Lutyens' Delhi following a Delhi High Court order to clear the area and ensure the rehabilitation of residents, officials said.

The court directed authorities to clear out three slum areas near the prime minister's residence in Race Course locality and instructed that camps be set up at rehabilitation sites to address grievances, according to officials.

The Bhai Ram camp, DID camp and Masjid Camp are the three clusters being relocated, they said.

According to officials, the land belongs to the Land and Development Office (L&DO) and the drive is being carried out with the help of authorities.

"The rehabilitation drive is being conducted after the court's order.

"Residents have been allocated residences in Narela," an official said, adding that residents have raised concerns regarding shifting which are being addressed.

The land was required for security and defence infrastructure, officials said, adding that ample security has been deployed to carry out the drive.

"We have deployed a police force and paramilitary to maintain law and order," a senior police officer said.

Man stabbed to death over altercation in east Delhi park, 3 juveniles apprehended

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A man was allegedly stabbed to death following an altercation with three juveniles at a park in east Delhi's Kondli area on Sunday, an official said.

Police has apprehended the three accused juveniles. According to the official, a PCR call was received at 12.03 am on Sunday reporting a person lying injured at DDA Park, Kondli, in Mayur Vihar Phase-III.

The victim was shifted to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead.

"During the investigation, it



emerged that the deceased had visited the park on Saturday evening along with two friends. Around 11.30 pm, while they were leaving the park, a minor collision allegedly led to a heated argument between the victim and three youths," the officer said.

The dispute soon spiralled into violence, during which the youths allegedly attacked the victim with a sharp-edged weapon, and stabbed him several times before fleeing the spot. Crime and forensic teams inspected the scene, and an FIR was registered based on eyewitness accounts.

“While they were leaving the park, a minor collision allegedly led to a heated argument between the victim & three youths”

During the investigation, police identified and apprehended the three juveniles allegedly involved in the incident, the official said, adding that further investigation is underway to establish the exact sequence of events.

Spa-based prostitution racket busted in Paharganj, 1 nabbed

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted an alleged prostitution racket operating under the guise of a spa in the Paharganj area and arrested a 29-year-old man accused of managing the illegal activities, an official said on Sunday.

Police said the action followed a tip-off regarding immoral trafficking activities in central Delhi.

A raiding team conducted a decoy operation to verify the allegations. A police constable, posing as a customer, entered the premises and was allegedly offered sexual services in exchange for



money, police said.

"The decoy customer handed over pre-recorded currency notes worth Rs 1,800 to the spa operator and was introduced to a woman for sexual services. After receiving a pre-arranged signal, the raiding team entered the premises and conducted a search," a senior police officer said.

“Police said the action followed a tip-off regarding immoral trafficking activities”

During the raid, police found evidence indicating that prostitution was occurring at the spa and arrested the alleged operator, Saved Ali alias Shabir.

Police said they rescued five women during the operation.

They said their identities have not been disclosed and that further investigation is underway.

Chhatarpur fire doused, no one injured: DFS

Confined to basement

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A fire broke out in the basement of a closed ground-plus-four-storey hotel building in the Chhatarpur area on Sunday evening, a Delhi Fire Service official said.

The official said the blaze was reported around 6:11 pm at a building in Dr Ambedkar Colony in South Delhi; multiple fire tenders rushed to the spot and doused the fire by 6:40 pm.

The official said the fire was confined to the basement where mattresses were stored.

No casualties were reported, he said.

AQI REMAINS 'MODERATE' City records below-normal max temp as IMD predicts rain and gusts for Monday

NEW DELHI: The capital recorded a maximum temperature of 38.5 degrees Celsius on Sunday, 1.4 notches below seasonal average, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

The weather department has forecast very light to light rainfall accompanied by gusts and thunderstorm on Monday afternoon and evening.

The maximum and minimum temperatures are likely to settle around 39 and 26 degrees Celsius, respectively.

On Sunday, the maximum temperatures logged across Delhi's key weather stations ranged between 38.4 and 39.1 degrees Celsius.

Ridge was the hottest at 39.1 degrees Celsius, 1.2 degrees above normal, followed by



Lodi Road at 38.7 degrees Celsius and Palam at 38.6 degrees Celsius.

Safdarjung, the city's base station, recorded a maximum of 38.5 degrees Celsius, while Ayanagar registered 38.4 degrees Celsius, 3.1 degrees

below normal.

The minimum ranged between 23.4 degrees Celsius and 26.2 degrees Celsius.

Safdarjung recorded the highest minimum temperature at 26.2 degrees Celsius, 1.8 degrees below normal, fol-

lowed by Palam at 25.6 degrees Celsius and Ayanagar at 24.8 degrees Celsius.

Lodi Road recorded a minimum of 24.6 degrees Celsius, while Ridge was the coolest at 23.4 degrees Celsius, 3.2 degrees below normal, IMD data showed.

Relative humidity was recorded at 61 per cent at 8.30 am.

The Air Quality Index (AQI) was recorded at 151, in the 'moderate' category, at 4 pm, Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) data showed.

According to the CPCB, an AQI between zero and 50 is considered 'good', 51 to 100 'satisfactory', 101 to 200 'moderate', 201 to 300 'poor', 301 to 400 'very poor', and 401 to 500 'severe'. MPOST

Bus overturns in Noida, at least 17 passengers injured

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: At least 17 passengers were injured after a sleeper bus travelling from Farrukhabad to Delhi overturned near the Mahamaya Flyover in the Phase-1 police station area early on Sunday.

Police said the accident occurred after the driver allegedly dozed off at the wheel, causing the bus to lose control, crash into a divider and partially overturn near a drain.

The impact triggered panic among the 29 passengers on board, with cries for help attracting the attention of local residents. Bystanders rushed to the spot, assisted in rescue efforts and alerted the police.

Teams from the Phase-1 police station and the Police Response Vehicle (PRV) unit

“Impact triggered panic among the 29 passengers on board, with cries for help attracting the attention of local residents. Bystanders rushed to the spot, assisted in rescue”

reached the site and, with the help of residents, safely evacuated all passengers from the damaged vehicle.

The injured were taken to the district hospital for treatment.

According to hospital authorities, the injured were identified as Mohit, Naseer, Azimul Rahman, Sunaina, Eliza, Sultan, Tanvi, Sharik,

Rakesh, Khushboo, Sameena, Irshad, Yunis, Mohammad Sahil, Furqad, Jaiveer and Tarrunum.

While most sustained minor injuries, eight passengers — Azimul Rahman, Eliza, Sultan, Tanvi, Sharik, Irshad, Yunis and Tarrunum — were referred to a higher medical centre for further evaluation and treatment.

The accident also damaged flower pots and signboards installed on the divider. Several parts of the bus, including its axle, were found broken due to the impact.

Traffic police later removed the vehicle with the help of a crane and restored normal traffic movement in the area. Police said no formal complaint had been received in connection with the incident.

AIMS TO PROVIDE DIRECT ACCESS TO SENIOR OFFICIALS, FASTER RESOLUTION

L-G’s public initiative: Weekly Jan Sunwai at all Delhi police stations

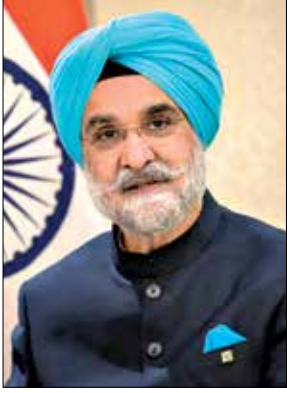
OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police will organise a weekly “Thana Divas-Jan Sunwai” at every police station across the national capital from next week to improve grievance redressal and enhance institutional accountability, a senior police officer said on Sunday.

The initiative follows directions from Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and aims to provide citizens with an open platform to raise complaints, seek assistance and share suggestions relating to policing and public safety.

Under the new guidelines issued by Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha, Jan Sunwai sessions will be held every Saturday from 10 am to 2 pm at all police stations.

“Senior officers from the



ranks of Special Commissioner of Police, Joint Commissioner of Police, Additional Commissioner of Police, Deputy Commissioner of Police and Assistant Commissioner of Police will attend the public hearings on a rotational basis to ensure prompt redressal of grievances and strengthen

TAKEAWAYS

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» ‘Senior officers from the ranks of Special Commissioner of Police, Joint Commissioner of Police,

Additional Commissioner of Police, Deputy Commissioner of Police and Assistant Commissioner of Police will attend the public hearings on a rotational basis to ensure prompt redressal of grievances and strengthen public confidence in the police complaint mechanism,’ the police officer said

public confidence in the police complaint mechanism,” the police officer said.

According to the circular, all complaints brought during the Jan Sunwai will be heard irrespective of whether they are registered on the Integrated Complaint Monitoring System (ICMS). Complaints

received during the hearings will subsequently be uploaded on the portal.

Police stations have been directed to maintain separate records of grievances received during the sessions, while complaints requiring inquiry or field verification must be acted upon immedi-

ately and disposed of within a reasonable timeframe.

The circular mandates periodic review of pending grievances by the concerned ACPs and DCPs. Station House Officers have been instructed to ensure proper seating arrangements, assistance desks and a citizen-friendly environment during the hearings.

“District DCPs have been asked to publicise the initiative through police station notice boards, social media platforms, Resident Welfare Associations, Market Welfare Associations and beat staff to maximise public participation,” the officer added.

The circular said that SHOs, ACPs and district DCPs would be personally responsible for implementation, warning that any delay, negligence or casual handling of grievances would be viewed seriously.

Delhi govt launches ₹10-cr infra projs in Pooth Khurd

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Minister for Social Welfare, SC/ST/OBC Welfare and MLA from the Bawana Assembly constituency, Ravinder Indraj Singh, on Sunday launched development projects worth nearly Rs.10 crore in Pooth Khurd village under the Delhi Rural Development Board (DRDB) Fund.

The projects include the strengthening of village roads, construction of cement concrete (CC) pavements, development of reinforced cement concrete (RCC) drains and other works aimed at improving drainage and civic infrastructure in the area.

According to the government, the projects are expected to significantly improve connectivity in Pooth Khurd and neighbouring areas, reduce waterlogging and enhance access to essential public services. Improved internal roads are also expected to facilitate smoother daily commuting and support local commercial activities. Addressing residents



‘Dev initiatives in Bawana Assembly constituency are being implemented at a rapid pace’

at the event, Ravinder Indraj Singh said, “Providing modern and improved infrastructure to Delhi’s rural areas through the Delhi Rural Development Board Fund is a key priority of the Government. The development projects launched in Pooth Khurd are not limited to the construction of roads and drains alone, but have been planned with a comprehensive vision for the village’s overall development, improved quality

of life and future requirements.” Emphasising the importance of basic infrastructure, he added, “Strong roads, an efficient drainage system and better connectivity form the foundation of sustainable rural development.”

The minister noted that development initiatives in the Bawana Assembly constituency are being implemented at a rapid pace. “Only a day earlier, development projects worth approximately Rs.20 crore had been launched in Deep Vihar and today projects worth Rs.10 crore have been initiated in Pooth Khurd. This reflects the Government’s serious commitment and focused approach towards the development of the Bawana Assembly constituency,” he said.

He further said the Delhi Government would continue undertaking projects to improve sanitation, transportation facilities and civic infrastructure to ensure that rural Delhi becomes an integral part of the capital’s growth story.

Over 150 firms to participate in IYC’s job fair on Rahul’s birthday

NEW DELHI: The Indian Youth Congress (IYC) on Sunday announced that more than 150 companies will participate in a mega job fair to be organised at the Talkatora Stadium here on June 19 to mark the 56th birthday of Congress leader Rahul Gandhi.

Addressing a press conference, IYC national president Uday Bhanu Chib said the job fair, being organised along with the Delhi Congress, will begin at 10 am and will be open to candidates ranging from Class 10-pass applicants to postgraduates.

“More than 150 reputed companies and institutions

from across the country will participate in the fair. Registration is completely free and candidates can also register on the spot if they have not enrolled online,” Chib said.

He said the recruitment process would be transparent and claimed that candidates selected by participating companies would receive offer letters on the spot. The Youth Congress said the initiative is part of its ‘Jobs, Justice and Accountability’ campaign. Chib alleged rising unemployment and paper leaks under the BJP-led Centre, while claiming previous job fairs had helped thousands. PTI

DERC set for leadership overhaul as Delhi govt seeks chairperson and two members

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has initiated the process to fill key vacancies in the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC), inviting applications for the posts of chairperson and two members of the electricity watchdog.

According to a notice issued by the Power Department on Saturday, eligible candidates with expertise in fields such as engineering, finance, commerce, economics, law and management can apply for the positions. Applications must be submitted via email to the Special Secretary (Power) at power.dercappointment@

“Prolonged vacancy has affected several crucial regulatory functions, including annual determination of electricity tariffs...”

gmail.com by July 3.

The move comes after the Delhi government constituted a three-member selection committee last month, headed by retired Delhi High Court judge Justice S.L. Bhayana, to oversee the appointment process. The committee has been tasked with recommending two names each for the posts of chairperson and members from among the eligible applicants.

The post of DERC chair-

person has remained vacant for nearly a year following the retirement of Justice (Retd.) Umesh Kumar in July 2025. In the absence of a chairperson, the commission’s functioning has been managed by its two serving members, Surender Babbar and Ram Naresh Singh.

Officials said the prolonged vacancy has affected several crucial regulatory functions, including the annual determination of electricity tariffs in

the national capital. The commission is also dealing with the recovery of pending dues amounting to nearly Rs 38,500 crore from Delhi’s three power distribution companies.

As per the notification, the chairperson and members will hold office for a term of five years from the date of assuming charge or until attaining the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier. They will receive a monthly salary of Rs 2.25 lakh, subject to adjustment against any pension being drawn by them.

The appointments are expected to restore the commission’s full strength and expedite pending regulatory decisions.

Property facing demolition order continues to function, raising questions over oversight

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Questions have emerged over the implementation of demolition orders in Delhi after an allegedly unauthorised commercial structure located on 100 Feet Road, Chhatrapur continues to remain operational despite a demolition order reportedly issued more than a year ago.

Documents reviewed indicate that the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) Building Department issued an Order of Demolition under Section 343 of the Delhi Municipal Corporation Act, 1957, dated 10 March 2025, against the property.

The order referred to alleged unauthorised construction and identified deviations involving the ground and first

floors of the structure.

According to the document, the owner/builders were directed to remove the unauthorised portions within the prescribed time period, failing which demolition action could be undertaken by the civic authority and related expenses recovered under provisions of the DMC Act.

However, recent photographs and public claims circulating online suggest that the structure remains standing and appears to be functioning commercially.

Visuals shared publicly indicate completed construction, installed commercial signage, furnished access points, external lighting and movement of visitors at the premises.

The issue has drawn atten-

tion amid the Municipal Corporation’s ongoing city-wide enforcement campaign against unauthorised constructions.

According to MCD’s Daily Action Taken Report, civic authorities reported action across the city involving demolition carried out on 202 properties, sealing of 212 properties, and issuance of 320 show-cause notices related to unauthorised construction. The report also recorded 120 sealing show-cause notices and 91 demolition orders issued during the period covered.

Against this broader enforcement backdrop, questions are being raised over the present status of the Chhatrapur property and whether subsequent action was taken after the demolition order.

Public concerns have also

extended to compliance and safety issues, with people questioning whether all necessary approvals and fire-related clearances required for commercial operations are in place.

These concerns have gained visibility amid recent discussions around urban safety and enforcement in the national capital.

The matter highlights a broader governance challenge of ensuring that regulatory orders are followed by timely implementation and transparent communication regarding enforcement outcomes.

Despite repeated attempts to contact civic and administrative authorities for clarification on the property’s status and enforcement action, no response was received till publication.

NDMC to offer 10% property tax rebate

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) has announced a 10% rebate on property tax for the financial year 2026-27 for taxpayers who clear their dues on or before June 30, 2026. The civic body said the initiative is aimed at encouraging timely tax payments while providing financial relief to property owners across the NDMC area.

According to the Council, taxpayers making payments within the stipulated deadline will be eligible to receive the rebate benefit, allowing them to reduce their overall tax liability for the current financial year.

NDMC urged residents and property owners to take advantage of the scheme and avoid delays in payment. Officials stated that early payment would not only help taxpayers

secure savings but also support efficient municipal revenue collection for civic development and public services. To facilitate a smooth payment process, the Council has enabled multiple payment options, including its online property tax portal and other authorised modes of payment notified by the authority.

The civic body also appealed to taxpayers to avoid waiting until the final days of the deadline, citing the possibility of increased traffic and processing delays closer to the end of the rebate period.

Residents can contact NDMC’s Tax Department or use official channels for assistance. The rebate scheme aims to encourage timely payments, improve compliance and enhance citizen-centric service delivery. MPOST

NDMC tree plantation campaign doubles as civic grievance forum

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal on Sunday led a plantation campaign under the #EkPedMaaKeNaam_OnSunday initiative at East Kidwai Nagar, combining environmental action with direct public engagement on local civic concerns.

The plantation drive, held at GPRA Type-II, III and IV residential areas, witnessed participation from Resident Welfare Association (RWA) representatives, local residents, Central Government officials and NDMC staff.

Addressing the gathering, Chahal said the event marked the 28th consecutive Sunday plantation programme under the campaign and highlighted NDMC’s continued efforts to promote environmental conservation through sustained public participation. He noted that similar plantation drives had also been organised in collaboration with universities,



embassies and other institutions. Describing the initiative as more than a symbolic exercise, Chahal said planting trees represents both environmental responsibility and a tribute to mothers and future generations. He urged residents to ensure regular care and protection of planted saplings to maximise long-term ecological benefits.

Highlighting broader environmental concerns, he appealed to citizens to place water bowls for birds during the ongoing summer season and emphasised that conservation extends beyond tree plantation to protecting the wider

ecosystem.

Before the plantation activity began, residents raised issues relating to water supply, horticulture services and local civic infrastructure. Chahal held discussions with department officials on-site and directed them to ensure prompt and time-bound resolution of concerns.

The NDMC also announced that plantation activities would continue every Sunday under a year-long Green Calendar aimed at expanding urban green cover and encouraging citizen participation in building a cleaner and more sustainable New Delhi.

CITIZENS URGED NOT TO DUMP WASTE INTO YAMUNA Mayor participates in riverbank clean-up

Nearly 29 tonnes of waste, silt, garbage cleared during Central Zone op

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) intensified special sanitation drives across all 12 zones of the city as part of the nationwide celebrations marking “12 Years of Citizen-Centric Governance”, with a renewed focus on cleanliness, waste management, environmental conservation and public participation.

The sanitation campaigns were conducted under the Swachh Bharat Mission and aimed at strengthening civic hygiene while encouraging residents to actively contribute to maintaining cleaner public spaces.

In Dwarka-A’s Ward No. 121, a cleanliness drive was organised in the presence of Member of Parliament Kamaljeet Sherawat, MLA Sandeep Sehrawat, Municipal Councillor Ram Niwas and MCD officials. Residents were urged to support sanitation efforts and adopt responsible



waste disposal practices.

Large-scale operations were also undertaken in the Central Zone, including stretches from M Block Market, East of Kailash to Kailash Hills Road and from NTPC Gate No. 1 to Jaitpur Chowk in Badarpur. More than 115 sanitation workers, supported by heavy machinery and waste collection vehicles, removed nearly 29 metric tonnes of garbage, silt and mixed waste from roadsides, open spaces and vulner-

able dumping points.

Similar drives were conducted across multiple wards in Karol Bagh Zone and at several locations in Rohini Zone with the participation of local representatives and residents.

Separately, Mayor Praveesh Wahi participated in the “Maa Yamuna Tat: Cleanliness Drive” at Dhai Pushta in Sonia Vihar to promote environmental conservation and riverbank restoration.

Joined by Deputy Speaker

“Similar drives were conducted across multiple wards in Karol Bagh Zone and at several locations in Rohini Zone with the participation of local representatives”

Mohan Singh Bisht, volunteers and sanitation workers, the Mayor undertook two hours of voluntary cleaning activity along the Yamuna riverbank. He said cleanliness campaigns had been conducted at 28 major ghats and appealed to citizens to refrain from dumping plastic, religious offerings and waste into the river.

Participants also took a public pledge to support a cleaner and greener Delhi.

Delhi Zoo launches weekly bird-watching initiative

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Zoo on Sunday launched a citizen science initiative aimed at promoting bird monitoring and biodiversity conservation through weekly bird-watching sessions. The inaugural ‘Sunday Bird Walk’ was held under the guidance of ornithologist Dr Paritosh Ahmad and birding volunteers.

Of 58 registered applicants, 23 participants, including students, birdwatchers and nature enthusiasts, joined the event. They documented 33 bird species and recorded more than 100 individual birds across the zoo premises.

Officials said the initiative seeks to generate biodiversity records while familiarising participants with scientific methods of bird observation and data collection. The programme will now be held every Sunday morning, with participation limited to 20 people on a first-come, first-served basis through the zoo’s website and NZP Sathi mobile application.

— INDIA, FRANCE TARGET DOUBLING TRADE TO USD 32 BILLION —

Modi-Macron talks yield 13 outcomes

NICE: India and France on Sunday set a five-year target to double their annual bilateral trade from the current USD 16 billion and unveiled an innovation road-map and a joint artificial intelligence framework to expand ties in critical sectors following talks between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Emmanuel Macron. The talks between the two leaders yielded 13 outcomes, including a high-speed railway cooperation declaration, a security pact for classified data, and an agreement to expand India's UPI payment network to the Paris and Nice airports. Modi landed in this Mediterranean French city on Saturday night as part of his week-long tour of France and Slovakia. Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said the Modi-Macron discussions covered the entire range of bilateral relations, including civil nuclear energy, defence, security, space, trade and investment, technology, innovation, education, mobility and people-to-people ties. In the meeting, India's plan to procure 114 Rafale fighter jets from French defence major Dassault Aviation figured with Misri



PM Narendra Modi with French President Emmanuel Macron during a visit to Villa Kerylos, in France PTI

asserting that the underlying focus was on having "maximum local content" in joint defence projects. Misri said talks between the two countries on the Rafale jet programme have advanced, adding PM Modi has been pushing for taking forward the "Make-in-India concept" as well as to follow "co-development, co-design, co-production" framework for defence projects. "There were talks on Rafale and other issues in today's discussions but I will say the underlying theme was that in case of any defence platform we will move

forward on the basis that there should be maximum local content, local manufacturing and our cooperation should be designed keeping this in mind," he said. The talks between Modi and Macron focused heavily on shoring up ties in technology and innovation, with PM Modi emphasising the need for a human-centric approach to scientific advancement. "A key focus of the discussions was also on strengthening and diversifying bilateral ties in the fields of economic growth, technology and innovation. This

Highlights

» PM Modi landed in this Mediterranean French city on Saturday night as part of his week-long tour of France and Slovakia

» Misri said talks between the two countries on the Rafale jet programme have advanced

is especially relevant in view of the conclusion of negotiations earlier this year on the India-EU free trade agreement," Misri said. The two sides also deliberated extensively on expanding cooperation in the civil nuclear energy sector, including with regard to the project in Jaitapur. "The discussion has primarily been carried on between EDF, Electricity de France and the Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited on both the technical aspects of this project and the very important financial aspects of the project." AGENCIES

From Page 1

PM

for humanity, human-centric innovation," he said.

The prime minister also highlighted his government's reform initiatives in several key sectors including high-technology, nuclear energy, defence and innovation.

"This momentum of reform will not stop; it will continue. And the number of startups emerging from India will also continue to multiply manifold."

Modi also delved into the importance of critical technologies for humanity even as he touched upon the impact of conflicts and various disruptions.

"This decade is one of both disruption and development for the world. Amidst conflicts and the escalating impact of climate change, the world is undergoing a period of unprecedented upheaval," he said.

"Yet, while humanity faces numerous challenges today, opportunities also abound. Artificial intelligence, quantum computing, biotechnology, space technologies, and advanced materials are the technologies that will shape the future of humanity. These represent the next chapter of human civilization," he said.

Modi said every technological revolution offers humanity a new opportunity, and every opportunity brings with it a new responsibility.

"Bharat Innovates is an invitation to the world to co-create the next chapter of global innovation with India," PM Modi, who landed in Nice Saturday night, said.

Modi further said India is innovating for a sustainable future. "India is innovating for the world," he said, adding innovation is in the country's DNA. "India has emerged not as a consumer of solutions but as a contributor to solutions in the world," he noted.

The prime minister also spoke about the strength of India-France relations. "India and France have a special partnership; it has connection, conviction, innovation, inspiration and shared vision," he said.

"And building upon the foundation of this relationship, we have jointly launched new initiatives over the years. We have given direction to new ideas. And we have made every possible effort to find solutions to global challenges," he said.

In his address at the event, President Macron said France respects the Make-in-India initiative and that Paris has been part of it in diverse sectors. Describing India as a "country of innovation," he said New Delhi and Paris have a "true partnership" in critical sectors like AI and climate change.

There is scope to expand bilateral cooperation in the civil nuclear energy sector, including in the area of Small Modular Reactors, he said.

PM Modi also held discussions with French President Macron on a wide range of areas, including AI, startups, trade, infrastructure, mobility and health, the Ministry of External Affairs said.

The two of them also exchanged views on key international and regional issues, it said.

PM Modi wrote on X that he had a very productive discussion with President Emmanuel Macron.

"Today's talks with my friend, President Macron, were exceptionally productive. Considering the longstanding friendship between our nations, we have decided to elevate our ties to a Special Global Strategic Partnership. Our talks covered ways to deepen cooperation in key sectors like defence, technology, space, security, counter terrorism, innovation and more," the PM wrote.

MEA's spokesperson Randhi Jaiswal said in a post on X: ``A further step to strengthen India-France partnership! PM @narendramodi held bilateral talks with President @EmmanuelMacron where they reviewed the progress in India-France Special Global Strategic Partnership."

He further said, "The leaders discussed areas including innovation, trade & investment, sustainability, security, culture and people to people ties."

"The meeting resulted in several outcomes in areas of innovation & AI, science & space, startups & fintech, trade & infrastructure, mobility and health among others. The leaders also exchanged views on key international and regional issues," he added.

In the ongoing tour, Modi will also attend the G-7 Summit, where he is scheduled to meet US President Donald Trump and other world leaders.

Arson angle

A total of eight people sustained injuries in the incident and were rushed to AIIMS Trauma Centre and Safdarjung Hospital for treatment.

Three victims later succumbed to their injuries. The deceased have been identified as Pankaj, son of Subhash Chand Pandey, Sushila Devi, wife of late Shivender Jha, and Sonia Kumari, daughter of Subhash Chand Pandey.

Initially, police registered a case under Sections 287 and 106(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), corresponding to the erstwhile provisions of Sections 285 and 304A of the Indian Penal Code, and began investigating the circumstances surrounding the fire.

However, during the course of the investigation, police examined CCTV footage from the area and discovered evidence suggesting that the incident was not accidental. Investigators noticed a woman entering the premises shortly before the fire erupted, leading them to suspect foul play.

Further inquiry led to the identification and apprehension of a 17-year-old girl from Navjeevan Camp, Govind Puri.

During questioning, the minor allegedly disclosed that she had been instigated by Sarita.

According to police, Sarita provided the girl with petrol and a matchbox and instructed her to set fire to a scooter belonging to Deepak, a resident of the building's fifth floor, due to a monetary dispute.

Police said Sarita subsequently revealed that the plan had been orchestrated at the behest of Niranjana and his younger brother Rajkumar.

Investigators believe the brothers allegedly conspired to carry out the act in order to settle a personal grudge.

Authorities stated that what was initially intended to target

a scooter escalated into a catastrophic fire that spread throughout the building, resulting in multiple casualties and extensive damage to the property.

Following these developments, Delhi Police invoked additional and more serious provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, including Section 61 (criminal conspiracy), Section 105 (culpable homicide), Section 110 (attempt to culpable homicide), Section 326(g) (mischievous by fire), and Section 331(4) (lurking house-trespass by night).

Deputy Commissioner of Police said the investigation transformed from what initially appeared to be an accidental fire into a serious criminal case after scientific and technical evidence pointed towards deliberate arson.

"The loss of three innocent lives in this incident is deeply tragic. Our investigation, supported by CCTV footage and sustained interrogation, revealed a conspiracy that allegedly led to the fire. All identified accused persons have been apprehended, and we are committed to ensuring a thorough investigation and strict legal action against those responsible," the DCP said.

The minor girl and all three accused have been apprehended in connection with the case. Police officials said the investigation is continuing to determine the full sequence of events, establish individual roles, and collect further evidence related to the alleged conspiracy.

The incident has shocked residents of the area, raising concerns about the devastating consequences of acts of arson in densely populated residential localities.

Authorities are continuing their probe and have not ruled out further legal action as additional evidence emerges.

PM to visit President's

Murmu of Pahadpur. Her husband and two sons passed away before she assumed office as the President in 2022. A memorial has been set up for Murmu's husband and sons in the village.

According to officials, a mega public event will be held at Dandabosh in Rairangpur on June 20. The function will be attended by the President and the prime minister, along with Odisha Governor Hari Babu Kambhampati, Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi and other dignitaries.

During the programme, several development projects will be inaugurated, foundation stones for new infrastructure initiatives will be laid, and the dignitaries will address a public gathering. "Before the public event, the President and the prime minister will visit Pahadpur village, where they are slated to participate in local programmes and tour an exhibition showcasing regional achievements and initiatives," an official statement issued by the state government said.

Meanwhile, the Odisha government has stepped up preparations for the VVIP visit to Mayurbhanj district. President Murmu is scheduled to arrive in Rairangpur on June 19, while the prime minister will join the state-level celebrations on June 20.

Ahead of the visit, Chief Secretary Anu Garg chaired a high-level

review meeting on Saturday and directed officials to complete all preparations within the stipulated timeframe.

The meeting was attended by senior officials of the Centre and the state government, along with other stakeholders. Officials from Mayurbhanj district, including the collector, eastern range IG and superintendent of police, participated virtually.

Discussions focused on security arrangements, protocol management, convoy movement, helipad preparedness, airport logistics, accommodation, healthcare facilities, fire safety, uninterrupted power and drinking water supply, road infrastructure, sanitation, telecommunications and media coordination.

Special Secretary, Home Department, Radha Kishan Sharma, presented a detailed status report on the preparations.

Obscure NCPI

Abhishek further stated: "The legislative party in the Lok Sabha derives its very existence from, and remains an emanation of, the political party. There is in law only one AITC, one Leader of the Party in the House, and one Whip, all of whom hold office by authority of the political party and its competent organisational authority. No member or set of members can, by their own volition, carve out a parallel 'group' or 'faction' of the same party and claim independent recognition within the House." He urged the Speaker to "decline any recognition of a separate faction of TMC".

He also cited the Supreme Court's 2023 Constitution Bench judgment in the Shiv Sena split case, contending that the defence of a "split" no longer exists under the Tenth Schedule. He maintained that even if two-thirds of a legislative party were to break away, they would not automatically qualify for protection under the anti-defection law unless there was also a merger of the political party itself.

After meeting the Speaker, Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar claimed that 20 MPs elected on TMC tickets had submitted a letter seeking separate seating arrangements. "These twenty MPs constitute more than two-thirds of our total strength. We are merging with the NCP. Moving forward, we will work for the nation and collaborate with the NDA under the leadership of the Prime Minister," she said.

"The NCP is a recognised regional political party. We have merged with it," Sudip Bandyopadhyay said.

Earlier in the day, TMC MPs Kirti Azad and Sagarika Ghosh met the Speaker to submit Abhishek's letter. After the meeting, Azad said: "In the Supreme Court's Constitution Bench judgment, it is clearly mentioned that a split cannot take place."

Senior Congress leader Kapil Sibal sharply criticised the move. In a post on X, he wrote: "TMC rebels: Will merge with Nationalist Citizens Party (NCP). Indian democracy has become the 'theatre of the absurd.' A joke! The rebels of the TMC legislative party cannot merge with a political party; that can happen only if the TMC wishes to do so! Disqualify them!"

Sagarika Ghosh told the media: "Rebel TMC leaders, who won

Peace deal on edge? Trump tells...

Continued from Page 1

Trump, who had said the deal could be signed Sunday, has pressed Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu to stop hitting Lebanon hard while a deal is near, but the prime minister has defied him. Netanyahu's office said the strikes were in response to Hezbollah attacks on northern Israel. Israel's military said Hezbollah launched three projectiles, releasing footage where an audible boom was followed by rising smoke. There was no immediate comment from the Iranian-backed Hezbollah. "Israel will not tolerate firing into its territory," Netanyahu and Defense Minister Israel Katz said in a statement. The military later said it was preparing for potential incoming fire in the coming hours.

An Associated Press photographer at the scene in Beirut said a five-story apartment building with shops on the ground floor was struck. The two lowest floors were the most heavily damaged. Residents of the southern suburbs, many of whom had returned home after weeks of relative calm, could be seen fleeing. Hezbollah fired missiles into Israel on March 2, two days after the US and Israel attacked Iran, sparking war in the Middle East. Israeli troops have since pushed their invasion of Lebanon deeper than at any point in over a quarter century. Iran wants a ceasefire deal to include the fighting in Lebanon.

Iran's parliamentary Speaker Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, a lead negotiator for Tehran, warned the US on X after Israel's strikes that "if you lack the will and ability to fulfill your commitments, speaking of continuing the path is not possible." "Without a doubt, these crimes

will not go unanswered," said Gen. Mohammad Jafar Asadi, deputy commander of Iran's Joint Command Headquarters, the official Mizan news agency reported. Qatari mediators travelled to Tehran on Sunday to finalise the agreement, according to two regional officials.

The officials, who spoke on condition of anonymity because they were not authorised to speak to the media, expressed cautious optimism that the US and Iran were finally approaching a deal that could halt hostilities that have killed thousands of people and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, whose closure has thrown world markets into disarray.

Pakistani Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif said Saturday the deal would be signed Sunday, while Iran's foreign ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei said it could happen in the coming days. Trump said the Strait of Hormuz would open immediately after the signing.

The deal is expected to be signed electronically, without an in-person ceremony, though it's unclear when or how the signing will take place. Iran's government warned that any division at home over the deal weakens its negotiating position, and those criticizing negotiators are taking aim at a national decision. Iranians must recognize that no war lasts forever, spokesperson Fatemeh Mohajerani told the state-run IRNA news agency. The deal does not solve the thorniest issues between the US and Iran, including Iran's nuclear program or its billions of dollars in frozen funds, but offers a 60-day framework for technical discussions on those issues, according to Pakistani and regional officials familiar with the ongoing negotiations. They spoke on condition of anonymity because

they were not authorised to speak publicly.

The officials described Pakistan's effort leading the negotiations, struggling for months to keep both sides from walking out on multiple occasions. Under the deal being discussed, US and Israel appear to have fallen short of their original goals of destroying Iran's missile and nuclear programs and ending its support for armed proxies in the region. It is not clear how the deal will address these issues, or if they will be part of the final agreement.

Iran's nuclear program and highly enriched uranium have long been at the centre of tensions with the US and Israel and an international source of concern. Trump on social media asserted Saturday that "when all is calm," the US would go in and "downblend and destroy" the enriched uranium in Iran or in the US. Iran has 440.9 kilograms (972 pounds) of uranium that is enriched up to 60 per cent purity, a short, technical step from weapons-grade levels of 90 per cent, according to the International Atomic Energy Agency. Iran has long maintained its nuclear program is peaceful and has not publicly committed to giving up the enriched uranium, which is believed to be buried under three nuclear sites that were badly damaged by US strikes last year. Critics in Trump's Republican Party, struggling with an unpopular war ahead of the midterm elections, have criticized the emerging deal. Some said it did not improve on the terms of the 2015 Iran nuclear deal that Trump withdrew the US from during his first term and which he still describes as "bad."

Meanwhile, Trump was expected to discuss demining the Strait of Hormuz during the Group of Seven summit that starts Monday.

undermine the safety, security and stability of international maritime commerce. AGENCIES

Rahul attacks

The Congress also said India must put off the upcoming visit of US Trade Representative Jamie Green and asserted that any self-respecting nation will do more than mere phone calls and press statements to defend its sovereignty against "bullies".

With Prime Minister Modi set to meet US President Donald Trump in France this week, the opposition party asked whether he will raise India's strongest condemnation over the sailors' killing in a US attack on a ship off the Oman coast, and the "threatening and really unacceptable" language used by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio in his conversation with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on June 12.

Gandhi slammed the prime minister, saying "our compromised PM" listens like an "obedient servant" and complies with the "orders". The leader of opposition in Lok Sabha also said that a "compromised PM" will not defend the nation's honour because he is beholden to those who insult the country.

His remarks come a day after the US said it conveyed to India that any violation of its blockade in the Strait of Hormuz and illicit transport of Iranian oil will not be tolerated.

US Secretary of State Rubio conveyed this to Jaishankar, who spoke with him on Friday to lodge a strong protest against the death of three Indian nationals in US attacks on ships off the coast of Oman.

In a post in Hindi on X, Gandhi said, "Just days after three Indian sailors were killed in American attacks there is neither regret nor apology. On the contrary, the US continues to issue orders."

"Read their words: 'Obey US military orders immediately.' No violation 'will be tolerated,'" he said.

"A sovereign nation would never tolerate such language. But our compromised PM? Silent. He listens like an obedient servant and complies with the orders," Gandhi said.

In another post in Hindi, he referred to the death of an Indian national due to medical complications aboard a vessel currently docked at the Duqm Port in Oman.

"Under a compromised PM, being an Indian means facing a wretched plight. Foreign powers kill our citizens. Our government meekly obeys orders like an obedient servant and our citizens are left to rot," he said.

"Bring this Indian home. Now," Gandhi said, tagging a post quoting the Indian captain of MT Celestial as saying that the body of his second officer is decomposing.

In his post on X, Kharage alleged that India's national interests are being surrendered on a daily basis.

"Even as the mortal remains of Indian seafarers killed in Oman by American action arrive in India, I join the nation in mourning the loss of the three Indian seafarers," Kharage said on X.

"Three days have passed since this tragic incident. Yet, there has been no public statement at all or even a condolence message from

PM @narendramodi," the Congress president said.

"The nation was waiting for it, Modi ji," he added.

"You spoke about 'desh nahi jhukne denge' but no proof is now required that you have belittled India's global standing and sovereignty," Kharage alleged.

CM leads Yamuna

keeping it clean." Emphasising that the responsibility extends beyond the government, she added, "The government will do its part, but citizens must also fulfil their responsibility to keep the Yamuna clean."

Gupta said the government has approved Yamuna rejuvenation and water management projects worth over Rs 1,000 crore. Among them are 12 decentralised sewage treatment plants being developed in Najafgarh under the AMRUT scheme at a cost of Rs.860 crore to prevent untreated sewage from entering the Yamuna.

Delhi Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, who participated in the drive at Hathi Ghat near ITO, said, "Yamuna is not just a river; it is an integral part of Delhi's cultural, spiritual and historical identity. Ensuring a clean and rejuvenated Yamuna for future generations is a collective responsibility that goes beyond governments and institutions."

Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta, who led the campaign at Chhath Ghat near Purana Loha Pul, said, "A clean Yamuna is the foundation of a healthy Delhi and a secure future." Stressing the need for public ownership of the mission, he remarked, "Expenditure alone cannot revive a river."

Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra, who took part in the drive near Yamuna Bank Metro Station, said, "Clean Yamuna, Healthy Delhi and a Better Future - this is our goal and commitment." He added that public participation would play a decisive role in transforming the future of the river.

Rajya Sabha MP Swati Malviya, who joined the clean-up at Kalindi Kunj, said, "I have been in politics for 15 years, but this is the first time I have participated in such a special Yamuna cleanliness campaign organised by a political party." Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh said, "We will ensure that within five years, Yamuna moves forward from Delhi in a better condition than the state in which it enters Delhi."

Former Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva described the Yamuna as "the foundation of Delhi's faith, culture and life," while MP Manoj Tiwari said the initiative was "not a one-day campaign." MPs Yogendra Chandolia and Kamaljeet Sehrawat stressed that the focus had shifted from announcements to time-bound execution, while MP Praveen Khandelwal highlighted the creation of a dedicated facility at Agrasen Park for the collection of broken idols. MP Ramvir Singh Bidhuri administered a pledge on Yamuna cleanliness to participants.

The Delhi government said similar drives would continue in the future, with sustained public participation forming the cornerstone of its efforts to rejuvenate the Yamuna and preserve it for generations to come.



EDITORIAL
CONTOURS OF
SCRUTINY

The controversy surrounding the rejection of Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan's nomination for the Rajya Sabha from Madhya Pradesh raises questions that extend far beyond the fortunes of a single candidate. At its heart lies a fundamental issue that is central to every democracy: how should electoral authorities balance procedural scrutiny with the broader objective of ensuring a fair contest? The matter has now evolved into a significant debate on the powers and responsibilities of Returning Officers, the interpretation of election rules, and the extent to which technical defects should influence democratic outcomes.

The Supreme Court's refusal to intervene at this stage is neither surprising nor unusual. Indian election law has long followed the principle that courts should not interrupt an ongoing electoral process. The Representation of the People Act, 1951, provides a specific remedy through election petitions, which can be filed before the relevant High Court after the election process is complete. This approach protects electoral continuity and prevents courts from becoming arenas for political contests before votes are cast or results declared. Yet the court's procedural restraint does not diminish the importance of the questions raised by the case.

Democracies thrive not merely because elections are held, but because citizens and political participants trust the processes governing them. The scrutiny of nomination papers is one such critical process. Returning Officers are expected to ensure compliance with legal requirements while simultaneously safeguarding the democratic right of candidates to contest elections. The law, therefore, grants them significant authority but also places corresponding responsibilities upon them.

The central issue in the Natarajan case concerns disclosure requirements and whether the omission cited by the Returning Officer constituted a substantial defect warranting outright rejection. Election laws rightly demand transparency from candidates. Voters have a legitimate right to know the criminal antecedents, financial interests and other relevant details of those seeking public office. Over the years, courts have repeatedly strengthened disclosure norms in the interest of informed voting. Concealment of material information can undermine public confidence and distort democratic choice.

However, the law also recognises that not every error is fatal. Election jurisprudence has traditionally distinguished between substantial defects and technical or curable defects. This distinction exists for a reason. Elections are not meant to be won or lost on clerical mistakes, procedural ambiguities or differing interpretations of complex legal provisions. The objective of scrutiny is to prevent ineligible candidates from entering the fray, not to create procedural traps that exclude legitimate contestants.

This is where the Election Commission's handbook assumes significance. Various provisions emphasise caution while rejecting nomination papers. The underlying philosophy is clear: rejection should be an exception rather than the rule. If there is reasonable doubt, electoral authorities are generally expected to lean towards inclusion rather than exclusion. Such an approach strengthens democratic participation while reducing the risk of disenfranchising voters who may wish to support a particular candidate.

The debate also highlights the challenge of interpreting disclosure obligations under Section 33A of the Representation of the People Act. Election law seeks to strike a balance between transparency and fairness. Candidates are required to disclose serious criminal cases under specified conditions, particularly where charges have been framed or convictions recorded. Yet legal proceedings often involve procedural complexities. Questions relating to cognisance, summons, complaints and preliminary hearings can create grey areas. When such ambiguities arise, the responsibility of the Returning Officer becomes even more delicate.

The concern is not merely whether the decision was legally correct. That question may ultimately be determined through an election petition. The larger issue is whether India's electoral framework provides sufficient clarity to minimise disputes of this nature. If experienced election administrators and legal experts can arrive at sharply different interpretations of the same provisions, it suggests a need for greater precision in the rules. Electoral certainty is a democratic virtue. Candidates should know exactly what must be disclosed, and Returning Officers should have little room for inconsistent interpretation.

There is also a broader institutional dimension. Election officials operate under intense political scrutiny, especially in high-profile contests. Every decision is examined through partisan lenses. In such an environment, transparency in decision-making becomes essential. Detailed reasoning, clear references to statutory provisions and adherence to established guidelines help build public confidence. Equally important is the perception that electoral authorities act without fear, favour or political pressure.

The episode should serve as an opportunity for introspection rather than partisan point-scoring. Political parties often champion procedural safeguards when they are adversely affected and dismiss them when they are beneficiaries. Such inconsistency weakens democratic discourse. The integrity of elections depends on principles that remain constant regardless of which party gains or loses. India's electoral system has earned global respect for conducting elections on an unprecedented scale. Yet the credibility of that system depends not only on voting day but also on every procedural step that precedes it. Nomination scrutiny may appear technical, but it can determine who gets the opportunity to seek public support in the first place. Decisions at this stage must therefore reflect both legal rigour and democratic sensitivity.

TALKING
SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN

THE WRITER
IS A VETERAN
JOURNALIST AND
COMMUNICATIONS
SPECIALIST

India's move to get higher ethanol levels into fuel tanks may reduce expensive dollar oil imports, but turning foodgrain into fuel while accelerating E85 adoption raises the risk of creating deadly economic and consumer fallout

ENDLESS
INSURGENCY



SHANTANU MUKHARJI

THE WRITER IS
A RETIRED IPS
OFFICER, ADVISER
NATSTRAT, AND A
FORMER NATIONAL
SECURITY ADVISOR
IN MAURITIUS

Experts strongly recommend that Pakistan regain the strategic space it has lost in Afghanistan, particularly through the development of an effective counterterrorism network

What Are You Burning?

As India speeds towards E85 petrol, the prospect of turning rice into fuel raises uncomfortable questions about economics, consumer choice and energy policy

"The essence of strategy is choosing what not to do."
— Michael Porter

The fuel in India's tanks may soon contain something more politically sensitive than crude oil derivatives. It may contain rice. As oil marketing companies introduce E85 fuel (with 85 per cent ethanol), policymakers are exploring new feedstocks to push India's ethanol ambitions. The most controversial is rice. In a country where food security is a cornerstone of public policy, converting grain into auto fuels raises itchy questions. Will we burn foodgrain in our engines, knowing feeding 140 crore people is a tough ask? Will taxpayers subsidise fuel produced from publicly-procured grain? Who bears the cost if the economics don't add up?

The instinctive answer is outrage. The thought-through answer is more complicated. Contrary to popular perception, ethanol made from rice is not markedly more expensive than ethanol produced from sugar-based feedstocks. Prices paid by oil firms for rice-based ethanol are comparable to those paid for ethanol produced from molasses. In instances, they can even be lower than ethanol derived from sugarcane juice.

That is what makes the issue more troubling. The question is not whether rice ethanol is affordable. It is whether converting procured foodgrain into fuel is the most sensible use of national resources. India holds grain stocks well above mandated buffer requirements. And maintaining these inventories costs crores in storage, transportation and handling. For policymakers, ethanol is an easy way to monetise the surplus. For taxpayers, food procured for India's strategic security is being turned into a 'suspect energy'.

Food or Fuel?
The timing of the transition is delicate too. Having only recently achieved full E20 blending, India is suddenly discussing E27, E30



India's ethanol debate is ultimately about balancing scarce resources, competing priorities and managing complex transitions wisely

and E85 adoption. A country that once debated whether ethanol should supplement petrol is now contemplating whether petrol should supplement ethanol. Ethanol usage began as an answer to a genuine challenge. India imports 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements, making it vulnerable to geopolitical shocks, supply disruptions and oscillating global prices. Every litre of ethanol cuts back that dependence, improves energy security and lowers foreign exchange burdens.

No one can dispute the logic. Indeed, the ethanol-blending programme has been one of the government's more successful policy interventions. Blending levels that once sounded ambitious have been achieved ahead of schedule. Distillery outputs have grown. Farmers have gained new markets for their produce. Ethanol blending is a rare example of a move that addresses energy security, rural incomes and environmental objectives in one single turn of the car key.

The challenge is that its success has fuelled demand. The more ethanol India blends into its fuel, the more feedstock it needs. Sugarcane and molasses can meet part of that demand, but not indefinitely. Maize has emerged as an alternate source. Rice is being discussed as the next frontier. This is why the debate becomes less about economics and more about public policy.

The Pricing Puzzle

For decades, India invested in food security systems to ensure that shortages never threatened national stability. The government procured foodgrain, maintained reserves and spent on storage and distribution. The underlying philosophy was simple: food stocks represented security. Now, some of those stocks are being used for fuel. Some feel surplus grain should not be allowed to languish in warehouses while the country continues importing expensive crude oil. Others feel that once food enters the fuel chain, the distinction between strategic reserves and industrial feedstock will blur. Both arguments have merit.

If this debate raises questions, the pricing of E85 raises some more. The E85 variant is being sold in Delhi at a discount to conventional petrol blends. That should be good news for consumers. But fuel economics are rarely straightforward. Ethanol contains less energy than petrol. Thus, vehicles running on higher ethanol content consume more fuel to cover the same distance. What matters is not the price of a litre of fuel, but the cost of travelling a kilometre.

This distinction is important because it raises unanswered questions. Is the pricing of E85 market-driven? Does it reflect the economics of production and distribution? Will such pricing remain sustainable if ethanol consumption rises? What happens if grain-based ethanol becomes

a larger share of the chain? The answers matter. Because public trust matters.

Engines and Consumers

The shift to higher ethanol blends is happening through policy direction, not consumer demand. Therefore, transparency is essential. Motorists have the right to understand what they are buying, what benefits they can expect and what trade-offs may have to be accommodated.

There is another dimension that deserves attention: vehicle compatibility. E85 is intended for flex-fuel vehicles that can handle high ethanol content. But the majority of vehicles on India's roads were bought long before E85 entered the picture. As crores of owners learn to adjust to the implications of E20 blending, policymakers are suddenly throwing in the monkey wrench of higher ethanol content.

So far, there is no proposal to force E85 on all vehicles. But consumers are cautious, especially with pure petrol disappearing from the retail fuel network. Many owners worry less about E85 than about where the ethanol drive will eventually reach. The concern is real. Ethanol transitions succeed when consumers have confidence in both the technology and the policy. They become problematic when car-owners feel that decisions are being forced on them. Energy transitions are not engineering drills; they are exercises in public consent.

Brazil's Lesson

No discussion about ethanol can avoid Brazil, which is a rousing example of ethanol adoption. There is much to admire in that success story, but there is also a lesson to be learnt. Brazil's romance with ethanol was gradual, forced on it after the oil shocks of the 1970s. The government invested in production capacities, vehicle tech and infrastructure. Consumers were offered a choice. Fuel stations sold various blends. Adoption was optional, not mandatory. Flex-fuel vehicles came in only after decades of technological evolution and

public acceptance.

By contrast, India seems determined to squeeze that journey into a fraction of the time. This speed may succeed too, for India's scale, tech capabilities and ambitions are very different from those of Brazil in the 1970s. But speed also introduces risks. Infrastructure must keep pace. Vehicle technologies must keep pace. Consumer awareness must keep pace. Else, the transition risks bloodying the noses of the very people it means to serve.

Measured Path
This is not an argument against ethanol. Reducing dependence on imports is a national objective. Energy security is a great national objective. India's ethanol plans have already delivered gains and deserves credit. But the next phase requires a new mindset. The goal should not be to maximise blending numbers or more ambitious targets. It should be to ensure that the shift is economically rational, technologically sound and socially acceptable.

If rice is to become fuel, policymakers must explain why that represents the most efficient use of India's grain. If E85 is to become common, people deserve clarity on pricing, efficiency and compatibility. If flex-fuel vehicles are to be the norm, the market should get the time to adapt. Any transition succeeds when citizens become willing participants, not forced passengers. The danger is not that India may embrace ethanol. It is that in the pursuit of energy security and forex savings, valid objections of the masses are dismissed.

The issue confronting India extends beyond ethanol. It touches on how it manages scarce resources, competing priorities and navigates the speed-bumps that accompany transitions. Before India decides how much ethanol belongs in fuel tanks, it first needs to answer a basic question – when food, fuel and policy begin to converge, which one are we willing to burn?

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Between Kabul and Chaos

Fresh militant attacks in Pakistan have revived concerns over Afghanistan-based terror networks, exposing security gaps and testing Islamabad's response

Once again, there appears to be no let-up in incidents of terrorism in Pakistan. According to the Pakistani media, after several months of decline in terrorist violence during March and April this year, a fresh wave of deadly attacks has raised new doubts over Afghanistan's alleged commitment to preventing the misuse of its territory against Pakistan. Over a span of five days beginning May 9, terrorists struck a police post in Bannu, a traffic police deployment in Lakki Marwat, and a security deployment in Bajaur, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa (KP). Interestingly, all the targets were police personnel in particular.

Reacting to the attacks, the Afghan Charge d'Affaires in Islamabad was issued a strong demarche by Pakistan's Foreign Office following the Bannu incident. It was a sophisticated attack involving a vehicle-borne improvised explosive device (IED) and a multi-pronged ground assault using heavy weaponry and quadcopters, claiming the lives of 15 police personnel. The Foreign Office stated that technical intelligence had specifically revealed that the attack was masterminded by perpetrators based in Afghanistan. The Afghan representative was informed that Pakistan reserved the right to respond, and the Defence Minister later warned that Pakistan would consider open war if the attacks did not stop. For a while, it appeared that Operation Ghazab Lil Haq had established a level of deterrence that would encourage the Afghan authorities to adopt a more proactive approach towards containing threats launched from their soil. However, the effect proved short-lived. China's involvement in the arbitration process between Kabul and Islamabad, which culminated in the suspension of kinetic measures after talks in Urumqi, also restrained Pakistan's response. But with the death toll mounting, pressure has once again begun to build for reconsidering military options. These developments have been extensively covered in the Pakistani media.

It may be recalled that Pakistan had previously demonstrated its willingness to use force to achieve peace and eliminate threats to its interests. According to Pakistani assessments, the Afghan side appears to be mistaking Islamabad's restraint for a lack of resolve, which could prove dangerous. At the same time, Pakistan maintains that it does not support violence as a means of achieving its security objectives.

Meanwhile, security experts believe that KP's security mechanism must work more closely with federal authorities, and that Pak-

istan's security establishment should adopt a proactive rather than reactive approach against infiltrating terrorists. According to Pakistani media reports, the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI)-led provincial government should also reconsider its narrative, which some critics argue has lent credence to militant propaganda, particularly regarding quadcopter attacks. Pakistani media coverage generally appears sympathetic towards criticism of the KP provincial government.

According to the widely read English daily Dawn, data indicate that terrorists launched 246 attacks this year alone, with a significant number targeting police personnel in Bannu. Critics argue that condemning the security apparatus while remaining silent on this sustained offensive against law enforcement reflects a double standard that must end. Better intelligence-sharing and coordination among police, federal security authorities and the armed forces would help isolate and target hostile elements more effectively. These developments suggest that Pakistan has been attempting various "trial-and-error" methods to control terrorism, but with limited success.

Assessing the terror situation, Dr Raashid Wali Janjua, a Pakistani security and defence analyst, has argued that acts of terrorism by groups such as the Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP), and now its equally virulent offshoots such as Ittehad-e-Mujahideen-e-Pakistan (IMP), have continued in a cyclical pattern since the launch of Operation Ghazab Lil Haq. The latest attacks, he says, are a grim reminder of the terrorism that continues to haunt both the newly merged and settled districts of KP. The persistence and impunity of the attackers reflect their determination to pursue their objectives despite suffering significant losses. In his assessment, Operation Ghazab Lil Haq was the correct decision, albeit one taken after a considerable delay, as it demonstrated the state's resolve to confront terrorism directly and without ambiguity. However, he argues that the reality of the battle against terrorism, which has both internal and external enablers, requires an honest appraisal of the underlying causes and factors that sustain it. Afghanistan, viewed by many Pakistani analysts as a principal source of terrorism, is governed by a leadership that came to power through armed struggle and is not necessarily constrained by public opinion or political compromise. These assessments largely reflect prevailing views within sections of the Pakistani media and security establishment. The ongoing assessment further argues

that, for this reason, the Afghan Taliban regime has been unable or unwilling to confront the diverse range of terrorist organisations operating within Afghanistan, each pursuing its own agenda. The Afghan Taliban itself is divided into multiple centres of power. The Kandahari faction, led by Mullah Hibatullah Akhundzada, combines spiritual and temporal authority and governs from Kandahar, traditionally regarded as Afghanistan's political heartland. It is often described as the most conservative faction. Another influential group is the Haqqani network, which draws support from the Zadran tribal leadership and exercises influence across eastern and northern Afghanistan, including Kabul. According to Pakistani analysts, this group has developed its own proxies, including the Ittehad-ul-Mujahideen Pakistan (IMP), to expand its reach beyond Afghanistan. A third significant faction is the National Resistance Front (NRF), comprising remnants of the former Northern Alliance, including Tajiks, Uzbeks and Hazaras, along with some anti-Taliban Pashtuns. Yet another power centre is the TTP, also referred to by Pakistan as Fitna tul Khawarij, which operates primarily in eastern Afghanistan, including Paktika, Paktia, Khost and Nangarhar. Analysts contend that both the TTP and the emerging IMP, reportedly aided by elements of the Haqqani faction, have extended their influence into Kunar province as well.

Terrorist organisations such as Al Qaeda and Islamic State-Khorasan Province (ISKP) also remain active in Afghanistan, with the latter maintaining a substantial presence in Nangarhar and Kunar. Recent assessments suggest that these groups have increasingly shared intelligence, training expertise and operational support, creating a coordinated ecosystem of militancy. Weapons and ammunition left behind by the United States following its withdrawal from Afghanistan are frequently cited as resources being used by these networks. As the TTP and its leader, Nur Wali Mehsud, reportedly moved closer to the Kandahari faction, the Haqqanis are said to have encouraged the rise of the IMP as a counterweight. According to these assessments, the IMP now possesses a larger pool of suicide bombers than the TTP. Smaller militant groups, including Lashkar-e-Islam and factions aligned with Hafiz Gul Bahadur, are also reportedly associated with the IMP. These, however, remain the assessments of Pakistani analysts, who are often viewed as adopting a pro-Pakistan and critical stance towards Afghanistan. Pakistani policymakers, therefore, must also recognise broader

regional realities. Externally, it is widely understood that Afghanistan's current rulers are influenced by both their ideological worldview and elements of Afghan irredentism.

Meanwhile, experts strongly recommend that Pakistan regain the strategic space it has lost in Afghanistan, particularly through the development of an effective counterterrorism network. Pakistan's military response has had some impact, but the continued survival of the TTP's senior leadership has ensured that its capacity to foment violence remains largely intact. Both the TTP and IMP are becoming increasingly active on social media and are making effective use of mobile technology for recruitment, planning and propaganda. While law enforcement agencies continue to pressure terrorists and their sponsors, analysts believe that Pakistan's political and diplomatic institutions must simultaneously engage with influential elements within the Afghan regime in pursuit of a diplomatic breakthrough. Such efforts, they argue, should continue in consultation with regional stakeholders including China, Iran and the Central Asian states. There is also the possibility of an internal conflict emerging between the Haqqanis, along with the IMP and NRF, on one side, and the Kandahari faction on the other.

From Pakistan's internal security perspective, it appears that both the TTP and IMP retain the capability to launch attacks against civilian and law-enforcement targets. In several areas, militants continue to find refuge through a combination of coercion and tribal affiliations, as local populations still fear them. According to security professionals, Pakistan requires a unified national response in which the KP government actively and effectively supports the federal government's counterterrorism efforts. Counterinsurgency expert David Galula advocated, among other measures, the strengthening of an "active minority" within the population capable of supporting the state and winning over broader public support.

Whatever these assessments may imply or however they may be interpreted, Pakistan has not yet been able to effectively contain terrorist violence, particularly in areas bordering Afghanistan. Much remains to be done to curb the menace, and strengthening intelligence capabilities remains a primary requirement. Addressing terrorism-related concerns should arguably take precedence over efforts to mediate in the Iran-US deadlock, which does not pose the same immediate security challenge to Pakistan.

Views expressed are personal

‘A FINAL VIDEO CALL, A LAST PHOTO’

Bihar families mourn IAF personnel killed in Assam plane crash

MPOST BUREAU

JEHANABAD/ARA: The last memories are now frozen on mobile phone screens. One mother recalls her son smiling during a brief video call; another treasures a photo he sent from inside an aircraft before an IAF plane crash in Assam killed five personnel, including their sons.

Flight Lieutenant Shubham Kumar from Bihar's Jehanabad and Agniveervayu Danish Alam of Bhojpur were among those killed in the Antonov An-32 transport aircraft crash on Saturday. The phones that carried cheerful video calls and photographs on Saturday morning soon delivered devastating news. According to family members, the flight lieutenant had spoken to his mother in Banwariya village via video call around 9 am on Saturday.

"Kumar looked cheerful and normal. He said that he was in a hurry and would speak at length later," a family member recalled. His younger brother, Satyam, said the family first learnt about the accident around 11 am, but found it difficult to believe.

The son of a farmer and a homemaker, Kumar had fulfilled his dream of serving the nation when he was selected as a Flying Officer in the Indian Air Force in 2021. Family members said marriage talks had recently begun, but he chose to put them on hold, insisting that his career and service responsibilities came first.

Back in his village, locals remember him as a humble young man who never forgot his roots and greeted everyone warmly whenever he came



IAF personnel carry the mortal remains of Flight Lieutenant Shubham Kumar in Jehanabad on Sunday

HIGHLIGHTS

► Flight Lieutenant Shubham Kumar from Bihar's Jehanabad and Agniveervayu Danish Alam of Bhojpur were among those killed in the crash

► The mortal remains of both officers were brought to their ancestral villages with full military honours on Sunday

Alam was her only son. Begum has two daughters.

"It was his dream to serve in the Indian Air Force. He planned his studies on his own and worked hard to achieve that goal," Begum said.

Friends and neighbours described him as a determined young man who carried the hopes of his family.

As news of the crash spread across the two villages, grief gave way to an outpouring of pride for the young men who had chosen to serve in uniform.

The mortal remains of both officers were brought to their ancestral villages with full military honours on Sunday.

A massive crowd gathered to pay their last tributes to Kumar.

Union minister Jitan Ram Manjhi, Bihar minister Pramod Chandravanshi, several sitting and former legislators, and senior police and district officials were present during the occasion.

Thousands of people chanting 'Saheed Aamar Rahe' thronged the native village of Agniveer Vayu Danish Alam when his mortal remains were brought.

home on leave.

In Kayamnagar village of Bhojpur district, Danish Alam's family is clinging to another final memory — a photograph he sent from inside an aircraft on Saturday morning.

"He had spoken to us over a video call on Friday evening, and he seemed very happy. On Saturday morning, he sent us a photo of himself sitting inside an aircraft. We later went to the Ara market, and while we were there, news of the crash reached us. We rushed back home," said his mother, Akhtari Begum.

CIC asks CBSE to reveal Board exam costs & tender process under RTI Act

Panel sets aside denial of information, asks to furnish revised replies

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Central Information Commission (CIC) has directed the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) to disclose "point-wise categorical" information permissible under the RTI Act related to expenditure on exams and details of answer books, including the tendering and procurement process, for Class 10 and Class 12 board examinations.

After setting aside the CBSE's earlier denial of information under the RTI, the transparency panel asked it to furnish revised replies and said that the information exempt from disclosure may be redacted or masked under Section 10 of the RTI Act, while any denial under Section 8(1)(d) should be properly justified.

The case arose from an RTI application seeking details of answer books used in Class



FILE PIC

10 and Class 12 board examinations during the 2023-24 and 2024-25 sessions, including paper quality, number of pages, size, purchase cost, total expenditure, GST payments and details of the tender process for procurement of answer sheets. In its response, the CBSE disclosed certain specifications of the answer books, stating that the paper used ranged from 60 GSM to 120 GSM, answer books contained 8, 20, 32, 40 or 48 pages and were available in sizes of 22 x 28 cm and 37.5 x 54.5 cm.

The board also said records

regarding the weight of individual answer books were not maintained. However, information relating to the purchase cost of answer books, the number purchased and total expenditure incurred on procurement was denied under Section 8(1)(e) of the RTI Act.

On queries regarding the tender process, names of participating firms, rates quoted and vendor selection, the CBSE said the matter was related to "confidential" and "sensitive" activities of board examinations and claimed exemption under sections 8(1)(d), 8(1)(e) and 8(1)

(g) of the Act.

The board also stated that expenditure data for examination fees was maintained on a financial year basis instead of academic sessions and declined to provide specific expenditure details. It also informed the applicant that expenditure on practical examinations was booked under a broader expenditure head and could not be segregated separately.

The appellant challenged the response before the CIC, arguing that larger public interest and transparency warranted disclosure of the information.

Information Commissioner Sudha Rani Relangi observed that the core issue in the appeal was the denial of information related to the "tender process for purchase of answer sheet and other related stationary materials" despite the appellant's contention that larger public interest justified disclosure.

Book by CISF officer champions self-belief

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Hogi Jay... Hey Purushottam Naveen!, a motivational book authored by CISF Senior Commandant Jay Prakash Azad, is attracting attention for its message of self-belief, perseverance and positive thinking. Inspired by 'Mahakavi' Suryakant Tripathi 'Nirala's celebrated poem Ram Ki Shakti Puja, the book encourages readers to discover their inner potential and face challenges with courage and determination.

Drawing lessons from the life of Lord Ram, the author presents adversity as an opportunity for growth rather than a barrier to success. The book emphasises that every individual possesses unique strengths



and a meaningful role in society, urging readers to remain focused on their goals despite setbacks.

Azad argues that true defeat lies not in failure but in giving up. Written in simple and accessible language, the book blends everyday experiences with reflections on personal development and social responsibility. It seeks to inspire confidence, reduce self-doubt and motivate readers to pursue their aspirations with clarity, resilience and a positive outlook.

Saini: Social institutions carrying forward legacy of national service

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said the true measure of a society lies not in its economic prosperity but in the way it cares for its weakest and most vulnerable sections.

Addressing the 346th Masik Vidhya Rashan Evam Sahayata Vitran Samaroh at Shree Gyan Sthal Mandir in Ludhiana, Punjab, Saini announced a grant of Rs 11 lakh for the Gyan Sthal Mandir Sewa Society.

Paying tribute to Lala Jagat Narain, founder of the Punjab Kesari newspaper, Saini said the veteran journalist devoted his life to patriotism, social harmony and service to humanity. He added that the spirit of selfless service championed by Jagat Narain continues through the work of the Gyan



Punjab BJP leaders welcome Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini in Ludhiana

Sthal Mandir Sewa Society and the Lala Jagat Narain Nishkam Sewa Samiti.

Highlighting the organisation's contributions, the chief minister said it has distributed ration to over 1.65 lakh needy widow families and extended

door-to-door assistance during the COVID-19 pandemic. The society has also provided tricycles to 385 persons with disabilities, distributed more than 1.15 lakh sewing machines to women and imparted computer education to over 25,000 children.

Saini said the Haryana government is implementing several schemes aimed at the social, economic and educational empowerment of women. Under the state's social welfare initiatives, widows receive a monthly pension of Rs 3,200. Eligible women are provided Rs 2,100 per month under the Deendayal Lado Lakshmi Yojana, while LPG cylinders are being supplied at Rs 500 under the Har Ghar-Har Grihini Yojana.

MPOST

Maha: 8 dead after pick-up van falls into roadside well



SOLAPUR (MAHARASHTRA): Eight people, including four women and four children, were killed while seven others were injured on Sunday when a pick-up vehicle carrying them plunged into a roadside well in Malshiras tehsil in Solapur district, police said.

Police said 15 people, hailing from Pandharpur and mostly relatives and neighbours, were returning from Mhaswad after visiting a temple when the incident occurred near Tandulwadi village.

"As per the preliminary information, the pick-up vehicle carrying 15 people suddenly veered off around 5 pm, entered a farm on the roadside, and fell into a well. It appears that the driver lost control of the wheel. Eight people, including four women and four children, were killed while seven others sustained injuries," said Atul Kulkarni, Superintendent of Police, Solapur.

He said the vehicle is being pulled out of the well, and the injured people were rushed to the hospital.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis has expressed grief over the loss of lives in the accident and announced a financial assistance of Rs 5 lakh to the next of kin of each deceased person. Describing the accident as "extremely unfortunate and tragic", Fadnavis stated, "I offer my heartfelt condolences to the deceased and share the grief of their families".

Fadnavis said seven people were rescued and are currently undergoing treatment.

He said the Solapur district collector and superintendent of police had immediately rushed to the accident site and that the state government is in constant touch with the local administration to monitor the situation.

MPOST

Kejriwal: AAP must return to power in Punjab to continue development

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Arvind Kejriwal on Sunday asked people to make Bhagwant Mann Punjab's chief minister again in the 2027 Assembly elections, saying that the state must not allow the good work being carried out by the AAP government to come to a halt.

Calling for support for the next election, the AAP supremo said: "Now we have only one task left. We have done so much work in five years, but there is still a lot more that remains to be done. We must make Mann Chief Minister again."

Kejriwal, along with CM Mann and other leaders, took out a roadshow in Mohali to thank voters for the party's victory in the recent municipal

corporation elections. He said Punjab had been "pushed towards ruin during the regimes of the Shiromani Akali Dal, BJP and Congress, when drugs spread across the state". CM Mann had worked tirelessly to pull Punjab out of that difficult period and put it back on the path of progress, he said.

Kejriwal added that no government in Punjab's history had received as much affection and public support after four-and-a-half years in office as the AAP government enjoys today, contrasting it with previous governments that, he said, had lost public trust to such an extent that people would not even allow their leaders to enter villages after a similar period in power.

Mann said the traditional

political parties had ruled Punjab for decades while protecting each other's interests. "For years, these parties looted Punjab and worked through an understanding that ensured power remained within their circle. Earlier, there were only two options before the people and both treated power like a game of musical chairs. They exploited public sentiments and plundered the wealth of Punjab. Today, the people have embraced the broom and cleansed the political system of the state," he said.

Today neither Sukhbir Singh Badal, nor Amrinder Singh Raja Warring, nor Partap Singh Bajwa are visible among the people because the masses are standing firmly with the Punjab government, he said.

PATNA: Police fired in the air, burst tear gas shells and took recourse to lathi-charge when a mob disrupted railway traffic on the outskirts of Patna, alleging a lack of an adequate number of trains for a competitive exam, officials said on Sunday.

Six people have been arrested, and a search is on to track down others involved in the mayhem at Patliputra station, where security personnel and railway officials were also left injured in stone-pelting.

According to Amresh Kumar, the Inspector General in charge of the Railway Protection Force for East Central Zone, which covers a major part of Bihar, trouble erupted around midnight when "more than 200 young men, posing as students appearing for com-



People cross a railway platform to board a train in Patna on Sunday

petitive exams" turned up at the Patliputra station.

Trains had been ferrying students to various parts of the state for the exams of the Excise Department scheduled on Sunday, Kumar said. "The troublemakers alleged that arrangements were inadequate

and squatted on the tracks, demanding a special train that could help them reach their destination in time," he said.

The IG, who had reached the spot along with a contingent of RPF and GRP, said that the police informed the railway authorities about the sudden

rush and, around 2 am a special train arrived. However, those squatting on the tracks refused to budge, and when police personnel tried to disperse them, they indulged in stone throwing, he said. "Normalcy was restored at the station, where tight security arrangements are in place, by 3 am. Though, as a last resort, we had to order lathi-charge and firing of tear gas shells," he added.

According to a statement issued by the office of SP, Railway, Patna, "Eight rounds were also fired in the air" to disperse the mob, and though an unspecified number of security personnel and other officials were injured in the stone-pelting, no hurt to passengers or damage to railway property was reported.

MPOST

IN RESPONSE TO NEW-AGE CHALLENGES

CISF boosts 'high-tech' security capabilities amid emerging threats

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: Facing an increasingly complex security environment marked by drone intrusions, cyber threats and emerging technologies, the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has launched a wide-ranging modernisation drive to enhance the protection of the country's critical infrastructure.

Over the past year, the force has strengthened collaboration with the Indian Army and the Indian Air Force while partnering with premier institutions such as IIT Madras to develop capabilities against evolving security challenges. Training in drone detection, tracking and neutralisation has been expanded significantly, with 7,120 personnel completing specialised courses in UAV monitoring and terrain analysis. To further bolster expertise, dedicated drone training centres are being set up in Hyderabad, Bhilai and Behror, while advanced academic collaborations have been initiated with

KEY POINTS

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- To further bolster expertise, dedicated drone training centres are being set up in Hyderabad, Bhilai and Behror
- Advanced academic collaborations have



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IIT Kanpur and the Defence Institute of Advanced Technology (DIAT), Pune.

The CISF has also intensified its Battle Inoculation Training programme in coordination with the Indian Army. Personnel selected through stringent National Security Guard (NSG) physical standards undergo specialised training in the Kashmir Valley, focusing on night operations, survival skills and close-combat techniques. As a result, 657 highly trained personnel are now deployed as quick-response teams across 49 airports in the country.

On the cyber front, the

force is contributing to the Union Home Ministry's vision of creating 5,000 Cyber Commandos. More than 1,600 CISF personnel have received specialised cyber-security training, while 35 officers are pursuing advanced studies in artificial intelligence, cloud computing and digital forensics through IIT Madras Pravartak. The force is also working towards recognition as a CERT-In empanelled auditing organisation. The CISF Fire Wing, comprising nearly 9,700 personnel across 23 sectors, remains a key component of its operational framework. In 2025, it responded to 2,889 fire inci-

dents, preventing losses estimated at Rs 172.55 crore. The wing also trained 450 personnel from civic fire services across 187 locations in advanced rescue and emergency response techniques.

Supported by Rs 450 crore under Modernisation Plan-V, the CISF is upgrading its training infrastructure with Digital Integrated Command and Control Centres and other technology-driven systems. Efforts to promote inclusion are also underway through a digital instructor management platform that reserves at least 10 per cent training positions for women.

NEW DELHI: In a significant step towards shedding colonial-era legacies and aligning military traditions with India's national ethos, the Indian Army has introduced sweeping changes to its dress regulations, ceremonial practices and official terminology under the newly issued Army Uniforms-2026 Pamphlet.

The revised manual removes several vestiges of British military traditions, including the mandatory carriage of swords by Reviewing Officers, the use of pouch belts with certain mess dresses and archaic terms such as "Royal". It also introduces the indigenous Bandi jacket as part of formal civil attire for officers.

According to the Army, the reforms are aimed at reflecting India's evolving sovereign identity while preserving the dignity and traditions of the force. A dedicated chapter titled "Indigenisation and Alignment with National Ethos" states that the changes are part of a deliberate effort to align military practices with contemporary Indian values.

Among the key changes, a closed-neck Bandi jacket will now be authorised as formal civil dress, worn with a full-

INSIGHT

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- Among the key changes, a closed-neck Bandi jacket will now be authorised as formal civil dress, worn with a full-sleeved shirt, matching trousers and closed footwear

sleeved shirt, matching trousers and closed footwear. The Army has also removed pouch belts from Mess Dress Nos. 5 and 6 and made sword carriage by Reviewing Officers optional.

The new regulations further restrict the ceremonial use of swords. They will now be carried only by parade commanders, contingent commanders and designated personnel during major ceremonial events such as Republic Day, Independence Day, Army Day parades and Guards of Honour. Reviewing Officers will no longer carry

swords during parades. The Army described the move as a balanced effort to modernise dress regulations while eliminating residual colonial influences. The pamphlet notes that the changes represent a progressive review of inherited practices, accoutrements and terminology.

The reforms also extend to operational attire. A new Battle Jacket has been introduced as standard winter outerwear for all ranks and will gradually replace the existing jersey-based winter uniform by June 2029.

The manual lays down detailed guidelines on personal appearance and conduct, prohibiting radical hairstyles, unauthorised beards, visible electronic gadgets, tattoos, body piercings and cosmetic make-up while in uniform. It also bars personnel from wearing uniforms at political, religious or protest gatherings, weddings, private functions and paid media appearances without authorisation. The latest measures follow a broader Army initiative launched earlier this year to remove colonial-era names from military establishments.

MPOST

India has worked to make quality healthcare more affordable: PM

Modi lauds healthcare facilities during last 12 years

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said the country has worked to make quality healthcare more affordable and accessible in the past 12 years, and the government will keep working on all such initiatives to build a healthy India.

Modi also said the government feels proud when “India is known as the nation with the world’s largest healthcare programme, Ayushman Bharat, which provides top-quality healthcare to the most vulnerable.”

“Over the last 12 years, India has worked to make quality healthcare more affordable and accessible,” he said in a post on X.

The Prime Minister said other efforts like PM Bharatiya Jan Aushadhi Pariyojana have made medicines, stents and knee implants affordable, and this has helped many people.

At the same time, he said, medical education has also become more accessible to people due to more institutions and seats being available.

“We will keep building on this ground covered so far in order to build a healthy India,” he said.

The ‘MyGov India’, a flagship citizen engagement platform of the Central government, stated that healthcare accessibility is one of the most important investments a nation can make.

“Over the past 12 years, under Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s leadership, India has made significant strides to ensure quality healthcare reaches more people, more



PM Narendra Modi

Highlights

- » Modi also said the government feels proud when “India is known as the nation with the world’s largest healthcare programme, Ayushman Bharat
- » PM said other efforts like PM Bharatiya Jan Aushadhi Pariyojana have made medicines, stents and knee implants affordable
- » The MyGovt India further said a stronger healthcare system starts with more doctors, better training and wider access to medical education

efficiently, and more affordably. The healthcare ecosystem today is more accessible, resilient, and future-ready for its citizens,” it said.

The MyGovt India further said a stronger healthcare system starts with more doctors, better training and wider access to medical education.

“Over the years, aspiring medical professionals have gained opportunities closer to home, including in regions that previously lacked such institutions. The result is a growing pool of skilled healthcare talent ready to serve a healthier India,” it said.

For millions of families,

the fight against TB is no longer being fought in the shadows, the platform said, adding that through early detection, wider screening, improved treatment access and community participation, India is accelerating its journey towards a TB-free future.

Some of the diseases that once posed major public health challenges are steadily being pushed into history, it said.

“Improved surveillance, stronger healthcare delivery, and sustained public health efforts are helping India reduce disease burden and move towards eliminating several preventable illnesses altogether,” it added.

‘Centre’s fuel sale restrictions may affect farmers’

WAYANAD: Kerala Agriculture Minister T Siddique on Sunday urged the Centre to reconsider its recent order regulating the sale of petrol and diesel through retail outlets, saying the move could adversely affect farmers who depend on fuel-powered agricultural machinery.

Speaking to reporters, Siddique said he has written to Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri and Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, seeking urgent intervention and requesting a review of the order.

The minister said the June 11 directive was intended to prevent large-scale storage of fuel, unauthorised bulk purchases and diversion of petroleum products to the black market.

Under the order, petrol pumps have been directed not to supply fuel to bulk consumers and to dispense fuel only into vehicle fuel tanks or containers approved by the PESO. MPOST

Jishnu Dev Varma: Why should there be controversy around Governors?

TARUN CHAKRABORTY

MUMBAI: Former Telangana Governor and current Maharashtra Governor Jishnu Dev Varma believes the perception linking Governors with controversy is “unfortunate”.

“Why should there be controversy? The roles are clearly defined. The Governor is the constitutional head, while the Chief Minister is the political and administrative head. Their responsibilities are distinct and should be respected,” he said.

The first person from Tripura to become a Governor, Varma earlier served as the state’s Deputy Chief Minister and Power minister. Recalling his tenure, he shared an amusing exchange with Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

“When I was given the Power department, I was not an engineer. Listening to discussions about transformers and generators all day left me disenchanted. I once told Modi ji about my limited knowledge of machinery. He replied, ‘Who told you that power is only about



Maha Governor Jishnu Dev Varma

transformers and generators? Power means bringing light into people’s lives. Think about how you can make their lives brighter.”

An alumnus of North Point School, Darjeeling, and a veteran BJP leader, he says politics has been a lifelong learning experience. “You can meet the most powerful people as well as a tea vendor. That is the beauty of politics—not power or elections, but the opportunity to interact with people from every section of society.”

He believes experiential learning was central to India’s traditional education system. “Even princes were sent to gurus. Rama, Arjuna and others

learned to live independently. Education was about life skills, not privilege.”

Mumbai is familiar territory for him through family ties with legendary musicians Sachin Dev Burman and Rahul Dev Burman. “Sachin Dev Burman was my father’s uncle and Rahul Dev Burman my uncle. Yet I have come here in a very different role—as the first Governor from Tripura.”

Deeply attached to his home state, he emphasised the need for investment-driven growth. “Employment comes through investment. Officials from Tripura should engage with industrialists and encourage investment in the Northeast.”

Kolkata also holds a special place in his heart. “For us, Kolkata was a city of memories... It was the cultural capital of India... and closely connected to our upbringing.” He noted that his grandfather, along with the Maharajas of Burdwan and Cooch Behar, helped establish the Calcutta Club in 1907 after being denied entry to the Bengal Club.

He spent much of his childhood in Darjeeling. “Darjeeling was very beautiful then. Today it has become much more crowded.”

Santiniketan remains another cherished memory. His father, Ramendra Kishore Debbarma, studied at Visva-Bharati and was a classmate of Indira Gandhi. The family also shared close ties with Rabindranath Tagore.

Recalling a favourite family anecdote, he said Indira Gandhi once informed Tagore that his father smoked cigars.

“Ramen, do you smoke cigars?” Tagore asked.

“No, Gurudev.”

“What do you smoke?”

“Sometimes cigarettes.”

“Where do you smoke?”

“Outside the ashram.”

The exchange became a treasured family story.

Though he once wrote regularly in Bengali and English, official responsibilities leave little time today. “I have stopped writing because I remain occupied with work. But I continue to read. Reading is a habit.”

Jharkhand CPI(ML) MLAs to cast votes for INDIA Bloc in RS polls

RANCHI: CPI(ML) Liberation general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya on Sunday said that both MLAs of the party will cast their votes in favour of the INDIA Bloc in the June 18 Rajya Sabha polls in Jharkhand.

He also alleged that the “ploy” chalked out by the BJP of supporting an Independent candidate would be foiled.

JMM candidate Baidyanath Ram, Congress nominee Pranav Jha and BJP-backed Independent candidate Parimal Nathwani are contesting for the two Rajya Sabha seats in the state.

“The CPI(ML) Liberation votes will go in favour of the INDIA Bloc candidate in the Rajya Sabha polls in the state. Our (two) MLAs here will cast their votes accordingly,” Bhattacharya told reporters, while addressing media persons here.

He said two polling agents have also been appointed.

“We hope the BJP’s ploy of fielding Parimal Nathwani as an Independent candidate will be foiled, with legislators voting against him,” he added.

The BJP-led NDA does not have the numbers in the state Assembly to make Nathwani a winner in the polls, unless there is cross-voting.

For victory, a candidate is required to secure a minimum of 28 first-preference votes.

In the Jharkhand Assembly, the INDIA Bloc has 56 members, comprising 34 from the JMM, 16 from the Congress, four from the RJD and two from CPI(ML) Liberation. MPOST

Peace unlikely in Manipur unless people possessing illegal arms are disarmed: CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IMPHAL: Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Sunday said that peace is unlikely in the state unless all the people who are in possession of illegal weapons are disarmed.

The illegal weapons, including firearms looted from the security forces and those purchased illicitly, have been used since the beginning of the ethnic violence in Manipur in 2023.

“Until and unless those in possession of illegal arms are disarmed, peace is unlikely in the state. Be it Meitei, Kuki or Naga, we are calling for disarming everyone. Several meetings with security forces have been conducted,” the chief minister told reporters.

Manipur Governor Ajay Kumar Bhalla had in February 2025 urged warring groups to voluntarily surrender weapons robbed from security forces and other illegally held arms. The state was then under President’s Rule, which was lifted a year later.

The chief minister said that Imphal valley is just 10 pc of the total state area, so more effective operations are needed in the hills. Imphal valley is home to the Meitei community, while the Kuki and Naga communities live in the hills.

At least 260 people were killed and thousands became homeless in the conflict between the Meitei and Kuki people since May 3, 2023.

“The total number of CoBRA battalions to be deployed in Manipur would be increased from two to three. Their operations would start after the necessary 45 days of training in the terrains and environment suitable to the state,” the CM said.

CoBRA (Commando Battalion for Resolute Action) is an elite, specialised unit of the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF).

Haryana to begin SIR of electoral rolls from June 15, confirms CEO

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Electoral Officer A Sreenivas on Sunday said the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls will begin across the state on June 15 in accordance with the directions of the Election Commission of India.

Under the exercise, booth-level officers (BLOs) will conduct door-to-door verification of voters and collect enumeration forms between June 15 and July 14, he said here.

Haryana currently has 2,06,55,929 registered voters and 20,629 polling stations. BLOs have been deployed at all polling stations and will visit every household to verify voter details. Enumeration forms provided to voters must be filled, signed, and returned to the

Sreenivas said BLOs will make at least three attempts to contact each household

BLOs, he said.

According to ECI directions, voters whose completed forms are not received will not be included in the draft electoral roll. Sreenivas said BLOs will make at least three attempts to contact each household.

“If family members are unavailable, the BLO will place the enumeration form under the door and leave a notice containing their name and mobile number, enabling the con-

cerned voter to contact them,” he said.

The ECI has specified 11 categories of documents for voter verification, including identity cards or pension payment orders issued to regular employees and pensioners of the central government, state government, or public sector undertakings.

Identity cards, certificates, or other documents issued before July 1, 1987, by the central government, local authorities, banks, post offices, LIC, or public sector undertakings; birth certificates issued by a competent authority; passports; matriculation or other educational certificates issued by recognised boards or universities are also included. MPOST

OUR CORRESPONDENT

HYDERABAD: The Cockroach Janta Party and other organisations staged a protest here on Sunday, demanding the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak and irregularities related to the CBSE’s on-screen marking system.

Protestors gathered in large numbers at Dharna Chowk here to voice their frustration against the NDA government at the Centre.

Activist and educationist Sonam Wangchuk, who attended the protest, stressed the need for making “bhaymukt Bharat” (fear-free India). He called for a functional



An activist during a protest staged by Cockroach Janta Party and other organisations, at Dharna Chowk, in Hyderabad, Sunday

democracy, urging Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s government to take accountability for the systemic lapses.

“And in the future, we

CJP holds protest in Hyderabad, demands Dharmendra Pradhan’s exit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

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Ayush ministry sets Guinness record for ‘most viewers for YouTube live yoga stream’

The record attempt was organised as part of the ministry’s outreach activities for IDY 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a landmark achievement ahead of the International Day of Yoga (IDY) 2026, the Ministry of Ayush created a new Guinness World Record on Sunday for the “Most Viewers for a YouTube Live Yoga Stream”, with 4,35,831 viewers joining a special global online yoga session streamed live through the ministry’s channel on the platform.

The record attempt was organised as part of the ministry’s outreach activities for IDY 2026 and witnessed enthusiastic participation from yoga practitioners, students, institutions, professionals and wellness enthusiasts from across India and around the world.

The event featured the Common Yoga Protocol (CYP) and reinforced the ministry’s vision of promoting yoga as a daily practice through the “Yoga 365” movement, according to an official statement.

The Ministry of Ayush recorded 4,35,831 verified viewers, surpassing the previous Guinness World Record of 2,46,252 viewers set in 2024.

“The new record exceeded the previous benchmark by 1,89,579 viewers, establishing a new global record for the largest viewership of a



Students perform ‘mayurasana’ (centre) and ‘vrikshasana’ (back) ahead of the International Day of Yoga, at Dr. Rajendra Prasad Ghat in Varanasi, Sunday

YouTube live yoga stream,” the statement said.

Addressing participants, Union Ayush Minister Prataprao Jadhav congratulated citizens across the world for contributing to the achievement.

“Today’s achievement demonstrates the extraordinary power of yoga to con-

nect people across regions, cultures and nations through a shared commitment to health and well-being. This new Guinness World Record reflects the growing global acceptance of yoga as a way of life and reinforces our collective resolve to make yoga an integral part of daily living.

Key Points

- » The Ministry of Ayush recorded 4,35,831 verified viewers, surpassing the previous Guinness World Record of 2,46,252 viewers set in 2024
- » The event featured the Common Yoga Protocol (CYP) and reinforced the ministry’s vision of promoting yoga as a daily practice through the “Yoga 365” movement

PTI

“As we move towards International Day of Yoga 2026, I urge everyone to embrace the spirit of ‘Yoga 365’ and contribute towards building a healthier, stronger and more resilient society,” the minister said.

Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary, Ministry of Ayush, said, “This achievement is not merely about setting a new world record, it is about the message we are sending to the world. The overwhelming participation demonstrates the growing recognition of yoga as a powerful tool for health and well-being. Our objective is to encourage people to embrace yoga not as a one-day event, but as a lifelong practice and make ‘Yoga 365’ a reality.”

Special messages from ministers, including Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs Kiren Rijiju, Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and Odisha’s Minister for Health and Family Welfare Mukesh Mahaling, were broadcast during the programme.

Congratulating the participants on the achievement, they underscored the importance of yoga as a tool for preventive healthcare and holistic well-being, and called upon citizens to embrace the spirit of “Yoga 365” by incorporating yoga into their daily routines.

Nation Briefs

ROHIT PAWAR ‘FIRM’ ON CONTINUING STIR OVER FARM LOAN WAIVER CONDITIONS

PUNE: NCP (SP) leader Rohit Pawar’s indefinite fast to press for removal of “stringent” conditions from the Maharashtra government’s farm loan waiver scheme continued for the third day on Sunday in Solapur’s Pandharpur town. He said that in view of the farmers’ plight, he was “firm” on continuing with the protest if the government does not meet his demand. The NCP (SP) MLA launched the stir on Friday in Pandharpur, the town famous for the Vitthal-Rukmini temple, to press for his demand for a blanket loan waiver for farmers. He belongs to the politically influential Pawar family from Bara-mati. He is the grandnephew of NCP (SP) chief Sharad Pawar.

MAHA: SARPANCH ALLEGES CORRUPTION IN FUND ALLOCATION, MINISTER DENIES CLAIMS

JALNA: Maharashtra Environment Minister Pankaja Munde on Sunday said she would resign if anyone had asked for even one rupee in her name after a sarpanch alleged that a 25 per cent “commission” was being demanded by some individuals for allocation of development funds. During her visit to Jalna, several sarpanches from Badnapur tehsil met the minister and expressed dissatisfaction over the distribution of development funds. A video clip of the programme showed a sarpanch alleging that a 25 per cent commission was being demanded in Munde’s name for a fund allocation.

‘LIC aims stronger mkt leadership as it approaches platinum jubilee’

LIC alone commands close to 60 per cent market share in the life insurance segment and manages assets of over Rs 57 lakh crore

NEW DELHI: Life Insurance Corporation (LIC) of India CEO and MD R Doraiswamy has said that despite rising competition in the life insurance sector, the Corporation will stay focused on strengthening its leadership position while contributing to the national development as it heads toward its platinum jubilee.

Insurance behemoth LIC alone commands close to 60 per cent market share in the life insurance segment and manages assets of over Rs 57 lakh crore. It has real estate properties valued at around Rs 60,000 crore.

The story of LIC, which completed its 70th year of existence, is inseparable from the story of India.

“As the economy grows, LIC grows. LIC growth helps the economy grow. So, it has been a synergistic kind of relationship that LIC has been having,” he said.

Reflecting on the organisation’s remarkable journey since its inception in 1956, he said that LIC’s growth has always been closely intertwined with India’s development.

Built on the vision, dedication and hard work of generations of employees and leaders, LIC has evolved into one of the



Doraiswamy further said LIC is actively considering establishing a fintech arm either through strategic investment or an organic way to cater to its growing digital needs

country’s most respected and trusted institutions, playing a vital role in nation building. “From 1956 to 2026 has been a journey which was intertwined with the development of the nation and we look at this organisation remaining fully prepared for meeting the needs of the country, for ensuring that the country moves towards Viksit Bharat and developing

Highlights

- » ‘As more players enter the market, our objective is not only to retain leadership but to maintain a substantial lead,’ Doraiswamy said
- » ‘Our aspiration for the 75th year, 100th year and beyond is to see LIC thriving, flourishing and contributing to nation development’
- » Besides national presence, LIC has its overseas operations in 13 countries through its branch offices, joint venture companies and wholly-owned subsidiaries

along with the country, and we will certainly look at growing in the way the country will expect us to grow. We would like to be a major player as we continue to be,” he said.

While outlining the LIC’s long-term vision, he said, “As more players enter the market, our objective is not only to retain leadership but to maintain a substantial lead. Our aspiration for the 75th year, the 100th year and beyond is to see LIC thriving, flourishing and contributing to nation development. That remains our core objective.”

LIC came into existence on September 1, 1956, through an Act, with the objective of spreading life insurance more widely and in particular to the rural areas.

By nationalising 245 Indian and foreign insurers and provident societies, LIC was formed by the Life Insurance Corporation Act, 1956, with a capital contribution of Rs 5 crore from the Government of India.

Today, LIC functions with 2048 fully computerised branch offices, 113 divisional offices, 8 zonal offices, 1,381 satellite offices and the Corporate office.

LIC’s Wide Area Network covers 113 divisional offices and connects all the

branches through a Metro Area Network.

LIC has tied up with some banks and service providers to offer an online premium collection facility in selected cities.

The insurer also has two wholly-owned subsidiaries and six associates, including IDBI Bank, LIC Housing Finance and LIC Mutual Fund.

Besides national presence, LIC has its overseas operations in 13 countries through its branch offices, joint venture companies and wholly-owned subsidiaries.

Doraiswamy further said LIC is actively considering establishing a fintech arm either through strategic investment or an organic way to cater to its growing digital needs.

“Naturally, to meet the modernisation requirement and particularly to bring innovation, we are engaging both fintech and insurtech players, and we are getting a lot of new things being developed by such players,” he said.

On the other side, he said, “We are a big financial institution investing in multiple organisations, and we also look at strategic investments in any specialised player as a way of improving the returns on the policyholders’ funds.” AGENCIES

New cos likely to invest in memory chip production in India: Vaishnaw

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: New companies are likely to invest in India to manufacture memory chips while existing investors will scale up production to address the demand-supply gap in the segment, Union Minister of Electronics and IT Ashwini Vaishnaw said.

Strong demand for memory (data storage) cards and advanced chips has tightened global supplies and supported higher prices in past quarters, and manufacturers have been sprucing up investments and production capacities to meet market requirements worldwide. The higher memory chip prices have, in turn, led to a rise in production costs for a range of electronic products, including smartphones and laptops.

“Definitely, a lot more investment is coming in the memory manufacturing units, and that is because for the first time in the way the semiconductor industry has grown at such a rapid pace, for the first time we are seeing a huge shortage of certain components which are required in the AI data centres, the high bandwidth memory chips,” Vaishnaw said.

Data centre investments in India are expected to cross \$200 billion soon, which may need billions of gigabytes of storage capacity. The minister said there is a global phenomenon of supply-demand imbalance, which is now getting filled up by setting many more units. “For example, there are



Union Minister of Electronics and IT Ashwini Vaishnaw

the high bandwidth memory chips, which are manufactured by Micron. They are the first plant to start commercial production on February 28th this year. This is the second plant which started commercial manufacturing on March 31st. These are the steps which have started giving results. There is a serious supply-demand mismatch in the case of memory,” he said.

When asked if there will be new investments in the memory chip segment or only existing players have plans to ramp up production, Vaishnaw said, “Looks like both might happen.”

He said the India Semicon Mission 1.0 could get about 48 startups to work on the tech products. “In ISM 2.0, that will be the topmost priority, design will be the topmost priority. The second biggest priority will be machines, which are used in the manufacturing of semiconductors. We will seriously be looking at getting the equipment manufacturers to come to India for designing the equipment as well as manufacturing the equipment,” Vaishnaw said.

The minister said that after decades of effort, India has been

able to attract chip makers to the country under Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s regime, as the India Semicon Mission 1.0 programme sets the foundation for a robust domestic semiconductor industry. He said that work is in advance stage for ISM 2.0, under which chip design will be a topmost priority.

The minister said the government will also look at the indigenous production of complex chemicals and gases that are used for manufacturing chips. “Of course, we will be adding many more fabs (chip manufacturing plants) and ATMP (chip packaging) units. We will be carrying forward the progress we made in talent development in the first version of the semiconductor mission,” Vaishnaw said.

Talking about rising investment in the data centre space in India, the minister said the large pool of talent availability in India is one of the basic reasons that is attracting companies from across the globe to set up their units in India.

“Second, our grid is practically a new grid. More than 2 lakh kilometres of transmission lines have been constructed in the last decade. Unbelievable upgradation of transmission is happening. It is a very robust grid. Third is the large availability of renewable energy in our country. Practically 50 per cent of our power generation capacity is from renewable sources,” Vaishnaw said.

He said that these three big factors are attracting the hyper-scalers to come to India.

Inflation data and crude oil prices to drive mkts: Analysts



NEW DELHI: Market investors would keenly track inflation data, the US Fed interest rate decision, and trends in crude oil prices to determine further movement, analysts said.

Besides, the status of the US-Iran deal signing on Sunday, trading activity of foreign investors and movement in global markets would also drive sentiments in domestic equities, experts noted.

Markets are likely to remain highly sensitive to developments surrounding the proposed US-Iran agreement, Ponmudi R, CEO, Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

Meanwhile, foreign investors remained sellers in Indian equities, dumping more than Rs 62,853 crore of shares in the first fortnight of June.

With the latest outflows, total withdrawals by FPIs from Indian equities have surged to Rs 2.87 lakh crore so far in 2026, surpassing the Rs 1.66 lakh crore pulled out during the entire calendar year 2025, according to data from the National Securities Depository Ltd (NSDL). PFI

Mcap of eight of top-10 most valued companies surges by ₹1.90 lakh cr

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of eight of the top-10 most valued firms surged by Rs 1.90 lakh crore last week, with ICICI Bank stealing the show, in tandem with a rally in equities.

“Indian equity markets ended a volatile week on a strong note, snapping a two-week losing streak amid improving global sentiment and supportive measures from the RBI aimed at attracting foreign currency inflows,” Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

From the top-10 pack, Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro and Hindustan Unilever were the winners, while Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC)



faced erosion from their market capitalisation (mcap).

ICICI Bank added Rs 56,223 crore, taking its valuation to Rs 9,61,297.77 crore.

HDFC Bank’s market valuation jumped Rs 38,571.11 crore to Rs 11,89,314.42 crore, and that of State Bank of India surged Rs 36,137.87 crore to Rs 9,38,661.50 crore.

The valuation of Bajaj Finance rallied Rs 18,366.57 crore to Rs 5,71,947.54 crore

and that of Bharti Airtel climbed Rs 14,380.14 crore to Rs 11,10,530.63 crore.

The market capitalisation of Larsen & Toubro edged higher by Rs 13,241.39 crore to Rs 5,57,197.83 crore, and that of Hindustan Unilever went up by Rs 10,984.34 crore to Rs 5,09,285.65 crore.

Reliance Industries’ valuation advanced by Rs 2,097.54 crore to Rs 17,49,418.94 crore. However, the mcap of TCS eroded by Rs 13,296.47 crore to Rs 7,82,049.62 crore, and that of LIC declined by Rs 822.25 crore to Rs 5,05,051.07 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued firm, followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, ICICI Bank, State Bank of India, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, Hindustan Unilever and LIC. PFI

‘Fuel prices to be reviewed based on crude oil supply’

THRISSUR (Kerala): Union Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi on Sunday said fuel prices would be reviewed based on the availability of crude oil supplies.

Replying to reporters’ questions on a possible revision in fuel prices, Gopi said the situation would be assessed based on crude oil supplies.

“Let us see the supply of crude oil. We have the minister concerned, Hardeep Singh Puri. Let it come,” he said.

He also asked reporters whether they had the role of a supervisory ministry.



Union MoS for Petroleum and Natural Gas Suresh Gopi

Fuel prices, including petrol, diesel and LPG, have witnessed hikes in recent weeks.

The increase followed disruptions in crude oil and natural gas supplies linked to the ongoing conflict in West Asia. PFI

Deceased 2nd IRBn personnel’s family gets ₹1 cr insurance claim from SBI

GANGTOK: A programme was held in the chamber of the DGP Sikkim Police Akshay Sachdeva, IPS on June 12, 2026, where a cheque for Rs 1 crore was handed over to the family members of a deceased Police personnel belonging to 2nd IRBn, Sikkim Police.

Also present in the meeting were officials from SBI: Teekam Singh Gehlot, General Manager NW-3, Local Head Office, Kolkata; Prashant Kumar Singh, Deputy General Manager (B&O), Siliguri; Alok Kumar Das, Regional Manager, RBO Gangtok; and Furba Tenzing Sherpa, Chief Manager Deposit and VAS, RBO Gangtok.

During the programme, the cheque was formally



handed over to the legal heir of the deceased by DGP, Sikkim Police Akshay Sachdeva and GM, SBI Teekam Singh Gehlot in the presence of senior formations of Sikkim Police and

other SBI officials. The benefit was extended under the provisions of the MoU for Police Salary Package executed between Sikkim Police and SBI on August 19, 2025. MPOST

US-Iran deal, crude oil movement to steer bullion prices: Analysts

NEW DELHI: Gold prices are likely to remain range-bound next week as investors await key monetary policy decisions from major central banks, developments in the US-Iran negotiations and movement in crude oil prices, analysts said.

Meetings of the Bank of Japan, the US Federal Reserve and the Bank of England, along with inflation data from the UK, the Eurozone, Germany and Japan, will be closely tracked for cues on the global interest rate trajectory. Analysts said the final-

sation of the US & Iran pact would remain a key trigger.

On the domestic front, gold futures for August delivery on the MCX declined Rs 5,066, or 3.2 per cent, during the week to settle at around Rs 1.50 lakh per 10 grams. Silver for the July contract fell Rs 2,351, or nearly 1 per cent, to Rs 2.46 lakh per kilogram.

In the global markets, Comex gold futures fell \$126.5, or nearly 3 per cent, during the week to close at \$4,238.8 per ounce, while silver declined \$1.13, or 1.6 per cent, to \$67.97 per ounce. PFI

R Natarajan takes charge as CGM State Bank of India, Kolkata Circle

NEW DELHI: R Natarajan has taken charge as Chief General Manager (CGM) of State Bank of India’s Kolkata Circle from June 2026. Having joined State Bank of India (SBI) in 1990, he brings over three decades of experience across retail banking, operations, credit management and overseas assignments. Before his current role, he served as General Manager of State Bank of India’s Patna Circle, overseeing operations in North Bihar. Natarajan is also a Certified Associate of the Indian Institute of Bankers (CAIIB). MPOST



R Natarajan

Tata Trusts to hike philanthropic spending to ₹2K cr this fiscal: CEO

CEO Siddharth Sharma hit back at media focussing only on ‘chaos’ in Tata Trusts that controls Tata Sons

NEW DELHI: Tata Trusts will increase its philanthropic spending to about Rs 2,000 crore in the current fiscal, according to its CEO Siddharth Sharma, who hit back at media focussing only on ‘chaos’ in the congregation of charities that control Tata Sons, the holding company of the over \$180 billion Tata Group.

Seeking to put “the record straight about the core activity of the Tata Trusts, for which we exist- philanthropy”, in a post on LinkedIn, Sharma bemoaned the media amplifying “certain narratives unfortunately, at times, without

verification & analysis- that happens”, terming it “both the reality and the tragedy of our times”.

Reflecting how the Tata Trusts came into existence and its purpose, he wrote, “As the majority shareholders in Tata Sons, we deploy, year after year, the dividends that we receive, into philanthropic causes that uplift those at society’s margins and help build a nation.

This predates, by 122 years, the CSR mandate that was introduced in 2014 for Indian business.

Sharma further said, “For FY25-26 alone, the philan-

CLOSER LOOK

» ‘As the majority shareholders in Tata Sons, we deploy, year after year, the dividends that we receive, into philanthropic causes,’ the Tata Trusts CEO said

» ‘For FY25-26 alone, the philanthropic spending of the Tata Trusts was Rs 1,600 crores approx., slated to go up to Rs 2,000 crores in the current fiscal,’ Sharma said

thropic spending of the Tata Trusts was Rs 1,600 crores approx., slated to go up to Rs 2,000 crores in the current fiscal.” This scale of spending, on a year on year basis, he said, “has enabled us to provide quality, yet affordable cancer care,

to citizens of Assam, Maharashtra, Jharkhand, Andhra Pradesh and UP”.

Sharma further said Tata Trusts is finalising a collaboration with a reputed educational institution to set up a world class university for

undergraduate studies, while it is also contributing to setting up a state of the art multi-specialty hospital in Central India, among other projects it is undertaking.

His post was in response to “someone offering to help me address the ‘chaos’ at the Tata Trusts”.

Sharma’s post comes amid simmering tension among trustees of the congregation of philanthropic bodies under the Tata Trust umbrella, which controls 66 per cent of Tata Sons, a situation that has continued since last year and now requires the intervention

of Home Minister Amit Shah and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman.

Notably, the matter of public listing of Tata Sons has divided opinion among the trustees, with Tata Trusts Chairman Noel Tata against it while Vice-Chairman Venu Srinivasan and another trustee, former defence secretary Vijay Singh publicly supporting it.

One of the trusts, Sir Ratan Tata Trust, is also facing an inquiry into alleged violation of norms related to composition of the board of trustees initiated by the Maharashtra State Charity Commissioner. PFI

Shweta said 'Mirzapur' gave her more than success as she looks forward to returning in Season 4

'CAN'T WAIT TO MEET GOLU AGAIN'

For Shweta Tripathi, 2026 has become a year of revisiting two important chapters of her creative life. While audiences associate her with the fierce and resilient Golu Gupta from Prime Video's hit series 'Mirzapur', the actress has also reconnected with the stage through the play 'External Affairs', nearly 10 years after her last theatre performance. Even years after its debut, 'Mirzapur' remains one of India's most talked-about streaming franchises.

As speculation around a fourth season continues, Shweta admitted to 'Variety India' that she eagerly awaits the opportunity to step back into Golu's shoes.

"Mirzapur" is pure love for us and Golu is, of course, incredibly special. With all these seasons, it's almost going to be a decade now. Not only have we earned money from it, but we have earned so much more - love, respect

Tripathi explained that Golu remains among the most meaningful characters she has portrayed

and connection. The cast and crew have become family. We have shared so much together," she said.

Since the series first premiered in 2018, viewers have witnessed Golu's dramatic transformation from a studious young woman into one of Purvanchal's most formidable figures in the power struggle. For

Tripathi, portraying that evolution has been deeply fulfilling.

Discussing her attachment to the role, she explained that Golu remains among the most meaningful characters she has portrayed: "Golu is super special. I love playing her. When we talk about archetypes, I think Golu is a warrior. She is a girl who continues to behave with dignity even in the most difficult circumstances. She is not a poster girl. The things she witnessed changed her completely, and that is deeply unfortunate."

The emotional weight of the character, however, was not easy to leave behind after filming wrapped. "Especially in seasons 2 and 3, I went into a deep rabbit hole and it took me time to come out of it. But I still love her so much."

Her excitement about the future of the series is equally evident. "I cannot wait for season 4. Fingers crossed. I'm praying for it. I am so excited. I can't wait to meet Golu again."

AGENCIES

MAIN VAAPAS AAUNGA

SHARVARI THANKS CAST AND CREW

Directed by Imtiaz Ali, it also features Vedang Raina, Diljit Dosanjh and Naseeruddin Shah

NEW DELHI: Sharvari shared a series of behind-the-scenes pictures from her latest film 'Main Vaapas Aaunga' on social media and expressed gratitude to the cast and crew.

Directed by Imtiaz Ali, it also features Vedang Raina, Diljit Dosanjh and Naseeruddin Shah. Sharvari recently shared the post on her 'Instagram' handle. It featured a picture of the filmmaker, her co-actors and other crew members. The actress said the film was 'built on the passion, patience, talent and hard work of so many people behind it'.

"This series is called 'People of Main Vaapas Aaunga'. A film may carry a few faces on screen, but it is built on the passion, patience, talent and hard work of so

'These photographs are a small love letter to the crew who made this journey so special,' she says

many people behind it. Every location, every scene, every emotion exists because an entire team showed up, gave it their all and believed in this story," she wrote in the caption.

She added, "These photographs are a small love letter to the crew who made this journey so special. Thank you for your dedication, your laughter, your resilience and your heart. Unfortunately, I couldn't photograph everyone, but sending my love to each one of y'all. And to everyone who has watched, supported, shared and embraced 'Main Vaapas Aaunga'."

PTI

Aaron recalls approaching Jesse Eisenberg for 'The Social Reckoning'

LOS ANGELES: Filmmaker Aaron Sorkin said he tried to bring back Jesse Eisenberg to essay the role of 'Facebook' founder Mark Zuckerberg in 'The Social Network' sequel, only to get turned away by the actor.



Sorkin, who wrote the screenplay for the first film, is also directing the sequel, titled 'The Social Reckoning'. He said he tried approaching Eisenberg for three days, but the actor rejected the offer. "I felt like it belonged to him and he was certainly battle-tested," Sorkin told 'Vanity Fair' in an interview.

He added, "He simply did not want to be conflated with Mark Zuckerberg anymore, because he has his problems with the guy. He doesn't like kids coming up to him in airports with business cards that say, 'I'm CEO, bitch' for him to sign."

PTI

Prioritise our own films, says Anurag Kashyap

NEW DELHI: 'Prioritise our own films,' said Anurag Kashyap as he slammed theatres for providing more shows to the recent Hollywood hit 'Obsession'.

Kashyap, who recently shared a post on his 'Instagram' story, said last week his directorial 'Bandar', featuring Bobby Deol, didn't get enough shows and now films such as Imtiaz Ali's 'Main Vaapas Aaunga', Singeetam Srinivasa Rao's 'Sing Geetham' and Manoj Bajpayee starrer 'Governor' are getting limited slots.

"I totally understand that everyone wants to see 'OBSESSION', but it can still run longer with lesser shows. If we don't prioritise our own films with better showcasing, then I don't understand how we will grow," he wrote.

Kashyap noted films are not getting enough shows, whereas 'Obsession' is dominating several slots.



"Last week it was with 'Bandar'. This week with 'Main Vaapas Aaunga', 'Sing Geetham' and 'Governor', while 'Obsession' is in six to seven shows," he added.

'Obsession' is directed by Curry Barker.

PTI



Ethnicity often influences casting, says Girija Oak

MUMBAI: Girija Oak, known for her work in the Marathi and Hindi film industries, said that perceptions of ethnicity play a role in casting decisions, sometimes benefiting artists and at times going against them.

"I haven't done any Marathi work in the last few years and of late, more Hindi projects have come my way. I've always been offered a variety of roles. Maybe I don't look Maharashtrian or maybe I do to some people. Sometimes your ethnicity can work in your favour and sometimes it can work against you. It's a strange game of perception," the Nagpur-born actress told PTI.

Oak has appeared in several notable projects, including 'Goshta Choti Dongraevadhi', 'Gulmohar', 'Baji', 'Taare Zameen Par', 'Shor in the City', 'Jawan', 'Inspector Zende' and the recently released 'Bharat Bhagya Viddhaata'.

She pointed to her casting in the 2025 series 'Perfect Family' by casting director Mukesh Chhabra as an example of how industry stereotypes can be challenged. In



She is known for her work in the Marathi and Hindi film industries

the series, Oak portrays Neeti Karkaria, a daughter-in-law navigating the complexities

and tensions of a dysfunctional Punjabi family. "Some people cast me for Maharashtrian characters because I can speak the language well and mix it with 'Bambaiya Hindi'. Although I don't speak that way in real life, I can work on it if the character requires it. So, if language and appearance are the only considerations, then it ultimately comes down to how people perceive me."

PTI

'I HAVE WORKED all my life to reach this level'

Nora opened up about sharing the FIFA World Cup 2026 lineup with Shakira and Burna Boy

Actress-dancer Nora Fatehi has been winning hearts globally after her electrifying performance at the FIFA World Cup 2026 opening ceremony. Videos from the grand event have gone viral across social media, with fans praising her energy, stage presence and ability to command a global audience.

Nora, who performed her latest track 'Siir Siir' at the prestigious sporting event, revealed the fascinating story behind the anthem's creation. According to the actress, the song was inspired by a powerful chant she heard from thousands of football fans during a tournament in Morocco earlier this year.

Speaking to 'Hindustan Times', Nora shared that performing at the FIFA World Cup 2026 opening ceremony has been both creatively fulfilling and transformative.

"The experience has definitely evolved me as an artist. It's been a fulfilling and inspiring journey. When I was attending the AFCON matches in Morocco in January, I heard almost 70,000 fans chant 'Siir Siir' in the sta-



dium during every game and I was in awe. The energy inspired me to reach out to producer Sanjoy and ask him to create a World Cup anthem using this chant," she said.

The actress explained that the infectious energy of the stadium crowd stayed with her long after the matches ended, eventually becoming the foundation of 'Siir Siir'. The anthem, released only a few days ago, has already generated significant buzz among music lovers and football fans alike.

For Nora, performing at one of the world's biggest sporting events alongside internationally renowned artists marked a major milestone in her career. Speaking

about being part of a star-studded lineup, she said, "It's been so exciting to be a part of such a massive mainstream lineup! I perform at the opening ceremony in Toronto while Shakira and Burna Boy do the opening ceremony in Mexico. I've worked all my life to reach this level, to be sharing opportunities with such icons!"

Nora also highlighted how global events such as the World Cup bring together artists, cultures and musical styles from across the world. "Being part of a platform that brings together different cultures, sounds and styles reminds me how powerful music can be in creating global connections."

AGENCIES

Performing at its opening ceremony has been both creatively fulfilling and transformative for Fatehi

